Biased Information, Biased Preferences: How Fragmented Media Environments Undermine Support for Redistribution*

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Abstract

When voters choose what to read about the economy, does the choice polarize what they want and whom they vote for, and does forcing the other side on them backfire? We answer with a pre-registered four-arm experiment on 4,524 German adults using two narratives about the 2022 to 2023 inflation surge. Respondents were either forced to read a left-leaning article on inflation's regressive incidence, offered it, or offered a choice between it and a right-leaning article on growth; the three arms separately identify exposure, selection on willingness to read, and selection on the direction of what is read. Selection is confirmatory: right-leaning respondents choose the growth article at 61–67%, left-leaning at 48–52%. Exposure moves preferences toward the narrative read: forced exposure raises a redistribution index by 0.10 standard deviations, and respondents who choose the left article end 0.27 above the control group, a contrast that combines its effect with who chooses to read it. Policy by policy: the left article moves preferences on wealth, inheritance and corporate taxes; the right article moves universal basic income. The two narratives act on different margins: the left article moves policy preferences but not support for the left platforms, while respondents who choose the right article are 3.8 points more likely to rank a far-right platform first, consistent with platforms that bundle fiscal with migration positions. Backfire is narrow: forced exposure lowers UBI support only among the most right-leaning fifth, who nonetheless update their factual beliefs as fully as anyone else. Individuals do not resist the fact, instead they resist conveying from the fact to the policy.

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1 Introduction

What people believe about inequality shapes how much redistribution they want. In the World Values Survey, 29% of Americans think the poor are trapped in poverty against 60% of Europeans; 30% think income is a matter of luck against 54%; and 60% think the poor are lazy against 26%. The welfare states differ accordingly (Alesina and Glaeser, 2004), and the beliefs are self-sustaining: where effort is believed to pay, low redistribution keeps it necessary (Bénabou and Tirole, 2006). Such divide is also seen within countries, and it follows the parties: explanations for who is rich and who is poor have polarized along partisan lines in the United States, while beliefs about inequalities politicians do not contest have not (Suhay, 2025). Beliefs about the economy are therefore not a summary of the facts. They are an input to policy, and they are formed largely through the media.

The media environment that forms them has fragmented. When a single medium reached everyone, it moderated: the arrival of broadcast television in the United States reduced the ideological extremism of members of Congress, consistent with a shift in voters' own views toward the center (Campante and Hojman, 2013). The problem is not only that people interpret the same facts differently but that they no longer see the same facts: after a single social-media intervention brought a British scandal to prominence, half of one party's voters had heard of it and a tenth of another's had (YouGov, 2025). Algorithmic curation reduces cross-ideological exposure and hardens prior views (Levy, 2021), and consumption is ideologically segregated online as offline (Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2011; Bakshy et al., 2015). In such an environment the tendency to prefer confirming information, confirmation bias, rooted in the discomfort of dissonance (Festinger, 1957; Lord et al., 1979; Taber and Lodge, 2006), hence, how information is supplied becomes more relevant than the underlying individual psychology.

This paper asks what that property does to preferences for redistribution and to the vote. Two literatures have studied the pieces separately. Information-provision experiments give respondents facts or narratives and measure the response (Kuziemko et al., 2015; Alesina et al., 2018; Andre et al., 2026; Haaland et al., 2023); they do not let respondents decline the information, so they measure the effect of exposure on a population that did not choose it. Studies of selective exposure observe which outlets people consume (Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2011; Chopra et al., 2024); they do not observe what the same people would have done under forced exposure. Yet the two decisions, what to read and how much to believe, are governed by one trade-off between the value of information and the cost of dissonance, and their interaction is the object of interest: if people avoid uncongenial content, exposure effects are effects on the wrong population; if they update selectively, who reads determines what the aggregate looks like. We write both decisions as consequences of one utility function, in which an accuracy motive meets two costs of dissonance, one incurred by exposure to a message and one by revising a belief, and design an experiment that observes the first at the moment of choice and the second at the moment of updating. Political scientists have combined forced exposure with

free choice to estimate the effects of partisan media on those who would and would not seek it out (Gaines and Kuklinski, 2011; Arceneaux and Johnson, 2013; de Benedictis-Kessner et al., 2019). Our design builds on theirs: it gives the willingness to read and the direction of what is read separate arms, and it measures the factual belief and the policy preference in the same respondents.

We study this interaction in the context of the 2022–23 German inflation surge, the largest in the country's post-war history. Most people believe that inflation hurts the poor more, but they divide along party lines over what causes it: in the United States, Republicans are more likely to blame government and redistributive spending, Democrats corporate profits (Binetti et al., 2024; Stantcheva, 2024). Household expectations respond to narratives (Andre et al., 2026), and inflation admits two coherent, politically coded readings: that it hits the poor hardest and calls for redistribution, or that it calls for growth rather than transfers. Both readings appeared in the German press. That gives the experiment two real narratives and a set of redistributive policies on which they disagree.

We embed a pre-registered randomized experiment in an online survey of 4,524 German adults, fielded between December 2024 and February 2025.[1] Respondents are assigned to four arms. A control group reads nothing or an unrelated text. A forced arm reads a left-leaning article on the regressive incidence of inflation, assembled from published reporting with its sources visible. An optional arm sees the article's headline and may open it. A choice arm sees the headlines of that article and of a right-leaning article that argues for growth rather than transfers and links the main welfare benefit to foreign recipients, and chooses one. The three arms separate the effect of exposure from selection on the willingness to read and from selection on the direction of what is read. Outcomes are six redistributive policies, a redistribution index, a ranking of four party platforms that bundle fiscal with migration positions, and, at the end of the survey, the factual beliefs on which the left article rests.

Our analysis yields four main empirical results. First, information selection is strongly confirmatory: 61 to 67% of respondents who voted for right-of-center parties choose the growth article, against 48 to 52% of those who voted for left-of-center parties, and the choice is predicted by partisanship and media diet, not by measured psychological traits. Second, exposure moves preferences toward the narrative read: forced exposure raises the redistribution index by 0.10 standard deviations. Respondents who read the article voluntarily end 0.19 above the control group and those who chose it 0.27, while those who chose the right article end 0.09 below; these contrasts combine the effect of reading with who chooses to read (Section 8.1). The effects are narrative-specific, and they split along the line between redistribution as taking from the rich and as giving to the poor, which engage different motives (Cavaillé and Trump, 2015): the left article moves the taxes on the rich (wealth, inheritance and corporate), the right article moves universal basic income, and both survive correction for multiple testing (the second at

[1] During the fielding of the experiment, inflation had fallen back to 2%. During that time the campaign for the February 2025 federal election took place.

the 10% level). Third, the two narratives are not mirror images. On policy the left article has the larger pull; on party preference, respondents who chose the right article are 3.8 percentage points more likely to rank a far-right platform first, while the left article moves policy without moving votes to the left platforms. We attribute the asymmetry to the bundling of fiscal and migration positions (Roemer, 1998): a respondent persuaded on economics can move only to a platform whose migration stance she accepts. Fourth, backfire exists but is narrow. Forced exposure lowers UBI support among the most right-leaning fifth of respondents by 0.18 standard deviations while raising it among the most left-leaning fifth by 0.12; it moves no other policy against the message. The same right-leaning respondents update their factual belief about low-income inflation as fully as anyone else, three-quarters of the way to the article's figure, the same as every other group. They accept the fact and resist its policy implication.

That last result is what the model was built to detect, and it relocates the mechanism. The cost of exposure governs which article is chosen; once it is read, opponents report its figure as readily as supporters; resistance returns at the step from the fact to a policy position. There, a cost of revising one's position explains why preferences move less than beliefs, the pattern Kuziemko et al. (2015) find for information about inequality. It cannot explain why, on the single most contested policy, the movement reverses. In the model, that requires either an identity motive to stand apart from the position the source advocates (Kahan, 2013) or a model of the economy in which the fact argues against the policy, and this wave cannot tell the two apart. Either way, the backfire is on the policy. Reported beliefs about the fact do not move against the article, in line with the replication evidence on corrections (Wood and Porter, 2019), although our knowledge questions cannot separate a belief from a remembered figure; and the reversal on one contested policy for one group is a narrow exception to the finding that attitudes move with counter-attitudinal evidence (Guess and Coppock, 2020).

The paper contributes to three literatures. To the work on beliefs about inequality and support for redistribution, it adds the realistic ingredient that people choose whether to be informed, and shows what that choice delivers: respondents who choose a narrative end far from those who avoid it, while offering and imposing the same article have similar effects on the redistribution index. To the work on the demand for news and selective exposure, it adds a randomized counterfactual (the same content under compulsion), as the hybrid designs do for partisan media, on a redistributive rather than a partisan issue. To the work on backfire and reactance, it adds a design that separates the belief from the preference and locates the resistance in the second. Relative to field evidence that media shifts votes (Gerber et al., 2009; Martin and Yurukoglu, 2017) and that conservative media has polarized asymmetrically (Grossmann and Hopkins, 2016), it offers a mechanism for the asymmetry that does not rest on the media's slant but on the structure of the political menu.

Section 2 sets out the model and its predictions. Sections 3 and 4 describe the experiment, the sample and the balance of the randomization. Section 5 states the estimating equations and the inference. Section 6 presents the results, Section 7 the robustness checks, and Section 8

the mechanisms, including the estimates of belief updating and what this wave cannot identify. Section 9 concludes.

2 Conceptual Framework

2.1 Motivation

A voter encountering economic news must first decide which sources to read adn subsequently decide how much weight to place on their claims. The two decisions have a counterpart in political science. In the Receive–Accept–Sample model of Zaller (1992), opinion depends on which messages a citizen receives and which she accepts, and she resists a message only if she can perceive its relation to her predispositions; in a fragmented media environment, reception becomes a choice. The literature on media and political attitudes has mostly studied the second decision, by providing information and measuring the response (Alesina et al., 2018; Andre et al., 2026); the literature on selective exposure has mostly studied the first, by observing which outlets people consume (Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2011; Levy, 2021). Yet the two decisions are governed by the same underlying trade-off, and a design that observes only one of them cannot say how they interact. If people avoid uncongenial content, then the effect of information measured under forced exposure is an effect on a population that would never have read it; if people update selectively, then the composition of who reads is a first-order determinant of what the aggregate response looks like. The framework below writes both decisions as consequences of one utility function, in which an accuracy motive meets two costs of dissonance: one incurred by exposure to a message, the other by revising a belief. Our four-arm design observes the first at the moment of choice and the second at the moment of updating.

2.2 Related Literature

The idea that beliefs are objects people consume and defend, rather than passive summaries of evidence, enters economics with Akerlof and Dickens (1982), who model workers choosing beliefs about job hazards subject to the psychological cost of contradicting them, and is developed into a general framework by Bénabou and Tirole (2016) and Bénabou (2015): agents trade the accuracy of a belief against its desirability, and information is valued not only for what it enables but for how it feels. Our two dissonance costs write that trade-off at the two points where it can bite: on exposure to a message, and in the revision of a belief. The specific functional form we use, a posterior that minimizes a weighted sum of squared distances to the signal and to the prior, is the directional-motives formulation of Little (2019), whose optimum is a convex combination of the two; it is also, as we note below, isomorphic to Gaussian precision-weighting, which is what makes its parameters interpretable to readers who prefer a Bayesian reading.

On the selection side, Chopra et al. (2024) show experimentally that demand for news reflects

both accuracy concerns and belief-confirmation motives, and that the second is substantial. Our first-stage utility is their tension in one line, applied to a redistributive issue rather than a partisan one. The older selective-exposure literature (Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2011; Levy, 2021) documents ideological segregation of consumption; the choice arm of our design produces the same phenomenon under randomization, with the counterfactual of forced exposure observed in the same sample. Hybrid designs in political science pair forced exposure with free choice to recover the effects of partisan media on those who would and would not seek it out (Gaines and Kuklinski, 2011; Arceneaux and Johnson, 2013; de Benedictis-Kessner et al., 2019); our framework adds an account of who seeks out what, derived from the same utility as the update.

On the updating side, two strands matter. Rabin and Schrag (1999) model confirmatory bias as the misreading of a signal in the direction of the current belief, and Fryer et al. (2019) show that when evidence is open to interpretation, agents encode it as prior-consistent and then update as if it were unambiguous; both provide micro-foundations for the discounting of a message that Section 2.5 allows, and both can carry it past reversal, moving the belief away from the message, when misreading is frequent or the evidence ambiguous enough. The second strand concerns whether updated beliefs translate into policy preferences. Kuziemko et al. (2015) find that information about inequality moves beliefs substantially but redistributive preferences only modestly, Alesina et al. (2018) find the response to mobility information is asymmetric by political orientation, and Stantcheva (2021) finds large partisan gaps at every step of people's reasoning about how taxes work, traced mainly to normative criteria and views of government. This gap between accepting a fact and acting on it is where our evidence on backfire turns out to sit (Section 8.3), and the second tier of our model describes it.

Finally, counter-attitudinal information can backfire on two different objects, which the literature has studied separately. Corrections of factual misperceptions were found to strengthen them among the ideologically motivated (Nyhan and Reifler, 2010), but across 52 issues no correction backfires, even among those whose politics it challenges (Wood and Porter, 2019). Exposure to opposing views on social media was found to make Republicans more conservative (Bail et al., 2018), but in three large experiments attitudes move in the direction of counter-attitudinal evidence, not against it (Guess and Coppock, 2020). Our model separates the two objects, and our design measures both in the same respondents. In the model, a cost of revising a belief can slow movement toward a message but never reverse it. Backfire on the fact requires the reader to discount the message by more than its full distance from her prior ($\rho > 1$ in Section 2.5); backfire on a policy requires an ingredient that acts at the step from fact to policy, and so should appear on one policy for one group rather than as a general response. One such ingredient is identity-protective reasoning (Kahan, 2013; Taber and Lodge, 2006): the fact is accepted, but its policy implication is resisted because it threatens a group-defining position. Explanations for inequality are group-defining in precisely this sense: the parties supply rival accounts of why some people are poor and others rich, and adherence to those accounts follows party lines (Suhay, 2025). Another is a model of the economy in which the fact argues against

the policy, so that a respondent who accepts the fact moves away from the article's conclusion with no wish to stand apart from its source.

2.3 Setup: Choosing What to Read

Respondent i chooses a source $s \in \{L, R, \text{skip}\}$. Reading s delivers a message $\hat{\theta}_s$: the position the article pushes toward on the question it argues. The two articles argue different questions. The left article states how much harder inflation hits low-income households, the incidence of inflation, on which the respondent holds a prior μ_i. The right article argues that growth rather than transfers is the remedy and that transfers feed inflation; we write μ_{iR} for her prior on that claim and set $\mu_{iL} = \mu_i$. What enters the choice is the distance between each message and her prior on its question, $d_{is} = \hat{\theta}_s - \mu_{is}$, and we assume that ideology moves the two distances in opposite directions: a respondent close to one article is far from the other. The utility of reading s is

$$u_i(s) \;=\; \alpha_i \lambda_i \, d_{is}^2 \;-\; \varphi_i \, d_{is}^2 \;+\; \varepsilon_{is}. \tag{1}$$

The first term is the value of information. A message far from one's prior has more to teach, because it contains what one has not yet heard. α_i is the weight the respondent places on accuracy, and $\lambda_i \in (0, 1)$, derived in Section 2.4, is the share of the distance she will close once she has read. The value of information is therefore net of the cost of revising her belief that reading brings: that cost lowers it but, as Appendix E.2 shows, never makes it negative or stops it from rising with distance. The weight α_i enters twice for a reason: it is the value of a unit of accuracy, and through λ_i it sets the share of the distance the respondent will close; under the normalization of Section 2.4, $\alpha_i \lambda_i = \lambda_i^2$.

The respondent chooses before reading, from the headline and a one-sentence description of each article. These cues tell her where an article stands relative to her prior, which is the distance that enters both terms of (1), and how far she can trust it. If she expects an article to be accurate with probability q_i, and uninformative otherwise, its value of information is $\alpha_i q_i^2 \lambda_i d_{is}^2$ (Appendix E.2). We assume that q_i is the same for both articles, so that accuracy alone cannot favour either. A common q_i scales the value of information of both articles alike, so at the selection stage it only sets the units in which φ_i is measured. At the updating stage it does more: if reading does not resolve her doubt about the article's accuracy, she closes a share $q_i \lambda_i$ of the distance rather than λ_i (Appendix E.2), so the updating weight estimated in Section 2.7 is $q_i \lambda_i$, a lower bound on λ_i. We set $q_i = 1$, under which the two coincide.

The second term is the cost of exposure: the discomfort of reading a message that contradicts what one believes, in the sense of Festinger (1957) and Akerlof and Dickens (1982), priced by φ_i. Unlike the cost of revising a belief, it is incurred by exposure and cannot be avoided by updating less. The idiosyncratic term ε_{is} is a standard taste shock. The respondent reads the source with the highest $u_i(s)$; skipping delivers no information and no discomfort. Reading may also carry a utility of its own, common to both articles, such as curiosity or the wish to

complete the survey as intended. It cancels in the choice between the two articles and matters only for whether to read at all.

The distance between message and prior thus enters both terms with opposite signs, and this is the crux of the selection stage: the article one expects to learn most from is the one that disagrees, and it is also the one that stings. When $\alpha_i\lambda_i > \varphi_i$ the respondent seeks out the counter-attitudinal article; when $\varphi_i > \alpha_i\lambda_i$ she selects the congenial one. The second regime shows up differently in the two arms with a decision. The choice arm offers both articles, and every respondent in it opens one, so a respondent with $\varphi_i > \alpha_i\lambda_i$ reads the congenial article. The optional arm offers only the left article; for a respondent to whom it is uncongenial, reading it carries a net cost of $(\varphi_i - \alpha_i\lambda_i)d_{iL}^2$, and she reads it only if the utility of reading itself outweighs that cost. Uptake in the optional arm can therefore be high and similar across the political spectrum (Appendix C) while the choice arm sorts: whether to read reflects the utility of reading, and what to read reflects the sign of $\varphi_i - \alpha_i\lambda_i$. The model is agnostic between the two regimes, and Section 6.1 lets the data decide.

2.4 Updating: How Much to Believe

After reading, the respondent forms a posterior on the article's question. We write this stage for the left article, whose figure the survey elicits and which is the only article assigned at random, so from here on μ_i is her belief about the incidence of inflation and $\hat{\theta}_s$ the article's figure; the same weights govern updating on the right article's claim. In the motivated-belief reading of Bénabou and Tirole (2016) the posterior is itself a choice: the respondent picks the belief θ that minimizes the loss

$$L_i(\theta) \;=\; \alpha_i\,(\theta - \hat{\theta}_s)^2 \;+\; \kappa_i\,(\theta - \mu_i)^2, \tag{2}$$

trading the cost of being far from the message against the cost of being far from her prior. The first-order condition $2\alpha_i(\theta - \hat{\theta}_s) + 2\kappa_i(\theta - \mu_i) = 0$ gives (Appendix E)

$$\mu_i^{\text{post}} \;=\; \mu_i + \lambda_i\,(\hat{\theta}_s - \mu_i), \qquad \lambda_i = \frac{\alpha_i}{\alpha_i + \kappa_i} \in (0,1), \qquad \frac{\partial \lambda_i}{\partial \kappa_i} < 0. \tag{3}$$

The posterior is a convex combination of message and prior, and the updating weight λ_i falls with κ_i, the cost of revising one's belief. Four remarks follow. First, (3) has the form of Bayesian precision-weighting with α_i in the role of signal precision and κ_i in the role of prior precision; the two readings are observationally equivalent in updating data alone, and we return to what separates them in Section 2.7. Second, only the ratio $\alpha_i : \kappa_i$ is identified from (3), so we normalize $\alpha_i + \kappa_i = 1$ and read $\lambda_i = \alpha_i$. This fixes the units of utility for the whole model, so φ_i is measured relative to $\alpha_i + \kappa_i$. Setting $\varphi_i = \kappa_i$, as a single cost of dissonance would, is then a restriction rather than a second normalization, and nothing in the model imposes it. Third, the model is solved by backward induction, but the revision cost cannot by itself deter reading. Given (2), κ_i prices the distance between the posterior and the prior: it is a cost of changing

one's mind, incurred only to the extent that one updates. A respondent who anticipates it can always update less, so it lowers the value of information but never makes a free article worth avoiding (Appendix E.2). Avoidance and confirmatory choice come instead from φ_i, which is incurred by exposure, whatever one then believes. The choice of what to read is therefore informative about φ_i, and the updating of beliefs about κ_i. Fourth, we call μ_i the prior, but the loss requires only that it be the belief the respondent holds, or states, before reading. It may be a belief she prefers to hold, as when beliefs are valued as assets (Bénabou and Tirole, 2011), or one she prefers to state: partisan gaps in answers to factual questions narrow when accurate answers are paid (Bullock et al., 2015; Prior et al., 2015). Whatever μ_i stands for, it is the belief the loss returns when there is no message, so the control group's answer measures it and the updating weight estimated in Section 2.7 is unaffected. What changes is what κ_i prices: the discomfort of changing one's mind, of giving up a belief one values, or of saying something one would rather not.

2.5 From Beliefs to Preferences, and Backfire

The outcomes of the experiment are policy preferences, so the model needs a second tier. Let y be a respondent's position on a policy, such as her support for a universal basic income, and $g_i(\mu)$ the position she would take if she held the factual belief μ: her own view of what the fact implies for the policy. We assume that before reading she holds the position her prior implies, $y_i^0 = g_i(\mu_i)$. Having formed her factual posterior by (3), she chooses her position to minimize

$$L_i^{\text{policy}}(y) \;=\; \alpha_i \left(y - g_i(\mu_i^{\text{post}})\right)^2 \;+\; \kappa_i^{\text{policy}} \left(y - y_i^0\right)^2, \tag{4}$$

the trade-off of (2) one level up: the cost of a position that does not follow from what she now believes, against the cost of revising the position she held. The solution is

$$y_i \;=\; y_i^0 + \lambda_i^{\text{policy}} \left(g_i(\mu_i^{\text{post}}) - y_i^0\right), \qquad \lambda_i^{\text{policy}} = \frac{\alpha_i}{\alpha_i + \kappa_i^{\text{policy}}} \in (0,1), \tag{5}$$

so the policy moves in the direction in which, for her, the fact points, scaled down once by the weight on the fact and once by the weight on the policy (Appendix E.3). Two features follow. First, the cost of revision now has two components, κ_i for the fact and κ_i^{policy} for the policy, and nothing requires them to be equal: a respondent can accept a fact fully and leave her position almost where it was, the gap between beliefs and preferences that Kuziemko et al. (2015) document. Second, a cost of revision at either tier can only slow movement. Both weights lie in $(0,1)$, so a respondent who takes the fact to point the way the article does ($g_i' > 0$) moves toward the article's position or stays put; she never moves away.

Movement away, backfire, therefore needs an ingredient that the trade-offs in (2) and (4) do not contain. There are three candidates, and they act at different points (Appendix E.4).

The first acts on the belief. A respondent who treats the article as a persuasive attempt may discount it by a share ρ of its distance from her prior, so that her effective weight on the fact is $(1-\rho)\lambda_i$, negative when $\rho > 1$. Minimizing (2) never produces this, since the optimal weight on a message is always positive, so ρ stands in reduced form. Rabin and Schrag (1999) and Fryer et al. (2019) provide micro-foundations for it, including $\rho > 1$: a signal misread often enough, or evidence ambiguous enough to be read through the prior, moves the belief away from the message, as can an inference about the sender's motive. Either way, $\rho > 1$ is the belief-level backfire that Nyhan and Reifler (2010) report, and both micro-foundations need a message that can be misread or read more than one way; a precise statistic leaves little room for either. The second acts on the policy, through identity. A respondent may value holding a position away from the one the source advocates, because her position marks the group she belongs to (Akerlof and Kranton, 2000; Kahan, 2013). Add a term $-\eta_i (y - y_s)^2$ to (4), where y_s is the position the article argues for. When that is the position the fact implies, $y_s = g_i(\mu_i^{\text{post}})$, the weight on it becomes $(\alpha_i - \eta_i)/(\alpha_i + \kappa_i^{\text{policy}} - \eta_i)$, negative when $\eta_i > \alpha_i$ (with $\alpha_i + \kappa_i^{\text{policy}} > \eta_i$, so that the optimum is finite): the movement reverses when the wish to stand apart outweighs the wish to hold the position the fact implies. This is what $\rho > 1$ amounts to at the policy tier, derived rather than assumed. If the article argues for more than the fact implies for her, a weaker identity motive suffices (Appendix E.4). The third acts on the mapping. A respondent who believes that transfers feed inflation reads "inflation hits the poor hardest" as an argument against a basic income, so that for her $g_i' < 0$: she accepts the fact and moves away from the article's conclusion, with both weights in $(0, 1)$ and no further parameter. People do reason from facts to policies through models of this kind, and the models differ by partisanship (Stantcheva, 2021; Andre et al., 2026).

The three accounts differ in what they predict, though not all can be told apart. The first implies that respondents for whom the article is uncongenial update their factual belief by less, or away from the article. The second and third leave the factual belief untouched, so that it moves no less for those respondents, and only the policy moves against the article. Because we observe both the factual belief and the policy preference, the design separates the first from the other two. It does not separate the second from the third, which differ in what the reversal responds to: who sends the message, under identity, and what the respondent believes the policy would do, under a different mapping.

2.6 Predictions

Prediction P1 (Selection)**.** If the cost of exposure dominates the value of information ($\varphi_i > \alpha_i \lambda_i$ on average), right-leaning respondents are more likely to choose the right-leaning article and left-leaning respondents the left-leaning one.

Prediction P2 (Updating)**.** Conditional on exposure, factual beliefs move toward the article's statistics with weight $\lambda_i \in (0, 1)$, and policy preferences move toward the position the updated

belief implies with weight $\lambda_i^{\text{policy}} \in (0, 1)$, most strongly on the policies the article names. Respondents who did not see a statistic do not update on it.

Prediction P3 (Narrow backfire)**.** Movement against the article is concentrated among respondents for whom it is uncongenial, and on the policies on which their resistance acts, rather than uniform across outcomes. If the resistance acts on the belief ($\rho > 1$), the factual belief of those respondents moves less, or away from the article; if it acts on the policy, through identity ($\eta_i > \alpha_i$) or through the mapping ($g_i' < 0$), their factual belief moves no less than anyone else's and only the policy preference moves against the message.

2.7 Taking the Model to the Data

The design identifies the model's comparative statics directly. Random assignment makes the comparisons between assigned arms in Section 6 causal, though not those between groups defined by their own choices (Appendix E.6); the choice arm tests Prediction P1; the forced and voluntary arms test Prediction P2; and the interaction of forced exposure with a predictor of right-article choice tests Prediction P3. Two objects in the model are, in addition, estimable at the group level from this wave. The two knowledge questions asked at the end of the survey elicit the factual beliefs on which the left article rests, and because the control group received no message, its answer is the counterfactual prior. For any arm, the updating weight is therefore

$$\hat{\lambda} = \frac{\text{posterior} - \text{prior}}{\text{signal} - \text{prior}}, \tag{6}$$

with the posterior the arm's median belief, the prior the control group's, and the signal the statistic the article asserts. Because the questions ask, without incentives and a few minutes after the article, what the rate was, $\hat{\lambda}$ measures how far reported beliefs move toward the article's figure, which may reflect recall as well as acceptance (Section 8.3). Table 9 reports $\hat{\lambda}$ by arm and, within forced exposure, by quintile of right-leaning propensity; the arms that never saw a statistic serve as placebos. What this wave cannot deliver is φ_i or κ_i at the individual level. The choice data identify only the sign of $\varphi_i - \alpha_i\lambda_i$: confirmatory sorting says that the cost of exposure outweighs the value of information on average, not by how much, and measuring φ_i requires pricing exposure directly. Recovering κ_i requires eliciting each respondent's prior before treatment, which we did not do to avoid priming, and separating it from prior precision requires a measure of confidence. Two further limits concern the policy tier. If identity is the source of backfire, the backfire says only that the identity motive outweighs the accuracy motive for the respondents who show it, as the choice data say only that $\varphi_i > \alpha_i\lambda_i$. And this wave cannot tell identity from a different mapping, since both predict the pattern of Prediction P3; separating them requires asking respondents what they expect a policy to do, which reveals the sign of g_i', and varying who sends the same article, to which only η_i responds. Section 8.4 sets out what a follow-up wave would need to measure them.

3 Experimental Design

3.1 Sample and Randomization

We embed a pre-registered experiment[2] in an online survey fielded in Germany between 12 December 2024 and 25 February 2025 through the Qualtrics panel, with a monetary completion incentive. Quotas on age, gender and education match population margins; Section 4 compares the sample with the 2021 federal election result to ensure representativeness along this dimension. Qualtrics assigned respondents to four equal groups by block randomization within age×gender×education strata. The control group was split evenly between a pure control (no text) and a placebo group that read a short text on the history of chocolate in Germany; our specifications pool the two, and Section 7 shows that outcomes do not differ between them (Table C.3).

Two attention checks screen inattentive respondents. The first appears immediately after the treatment block. It explains that respondents often answer survey questions without reading them, and then asks "What is your favourite colour?", instructing the respondent to answer *violet* regardless of their actual preference. A respondent who answers anything else is told that the answer is incorrect and asked again, up to three attempts; those who never comply do not proceed and do not appear in the data. Of the analysis sample, 3,640 respondents (80.5%) comply on the first attempt, 771 on the second and 113 on the third. Table 6 re-estimates the main results on the first-attempt compliers alone. A second check is embedded among the redistributive-policy items: formatted like the surrounding 0–10 questions, it instructs respondents to ignore the usual response options and select the value "seven".

The analysis sample comprises 4,524 respondents. Of the 4,533 who completed the survey, we drop two with missing education and seven whose federal state is not recorded; the latter are excluded because the federal state is the level at which we cluster standard errors (Section 5.3), leaving all sixteen German states represented. Figure 1 summarizes the survey flow; the questionnaire was administered in German and is reproduced in translation in Appendix B.

3.2 Treatments

The treatment block follows the stratification questions so that reading, which takes about two minutes, occurs at peak attention. Two texts are used. The *left-leaning article* ("Social gap in inflation at its highest level") documents the regressive incidence of the 2022–23 inflation surge and proposes an excess-profits tax, a wealth tax, and a higher minimum wage. The *right-leaning article* ("Handouts won't save Germany") argues that growth, not social benefits, is the answer and proposes corporate tax cuts. It also attacks the citizen's allowance (*Bürgergeld*), the main means-tested benefit for working-age adults, as a disincentive to work, and states that 40 percent of its recipients are foreigners without sufficient German to enter the labor market;

[2] AEA RCT Registry AEARCTR-0014878; ethics approval ZEW-EC-2024-001.

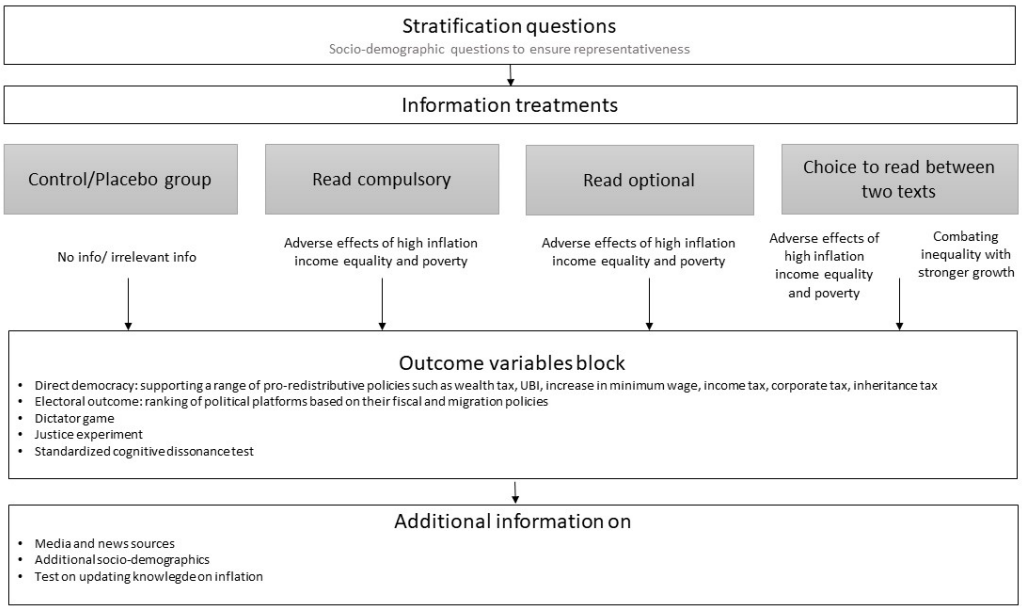


Figure 1. Survey flow. Stratification block, treatment block, outcome block, covariate block, and knowledge questions, in order of administration.

it therefore carries a cue on migration that the left article does not. Both are composites of published German reporting with the original sources linked in the text (TAZ, DGB, and the Hans-Böckler Foundation; Welt, Focus, DW, and the Financial Times), so that readers can see each article's political alignment. Full texts are in Appendix A. The three treated groups differ only in whether, and how, respondents choose what to read:

- **T1 (forced exposure).** Respondents are directly shown the full left-leaning article.
- **T2 (optional exposure).** Respondents see the left-leaning article's headline and a one-sentence description and can choose whether to open it; 87% do.
- **T3 (choice).** Respondents see the headline and description of both articles, in randomized order, and can choose one to read; 57% choose the right-leaning article.

T1 thus identifies the effect of exposure to the left article, T2 adds selection on the willingness to read it, and T3 adds selection on direction (Section 5). No arm assigns the right-leaning article: it is read only by respondents who choose it, so its effect is not identified separately from who chooses it (Section 5.3).

3.3 Outcomes

All groups answer the same outcome block. *Redistributive-policy preferences* cover six policies, phrased neutrally, e.g. "To what extent do you agree or disagree with the introduction of a wealth tax in Germany that requires high net worth individuals to pay a percentage of their total wealth as tax?" (0–10). Universal basic income and a minimum-wage increase use the same scale;

the preferred top income-tax rate for a €280,000 earner is a 0–100 slider anchored on the information that a minimum-wage earner pays about 27%; corporate and inheritance tax are sliders around their current rates. We summarize the six in a redistribution index, the first principal component of the standardized items (Section 5).

Electoral preferences are elicited by ranking four fictitious platforms that each combine a fiscal and a migration position (Table B.1), shown in random order with a blank-vote option; our outcomes are indicators for the platform ranked first.

Cognitive dissonance is measured by three 1–7 items on discomfort with opposing political views, whether disagreement leads one to question one's beliefs, and difficulty reconciling opposing arguments; they enter the propensity model of Section 5.4.

Distributive-justice orientation is elicited by a question in which respondents award a flute to one of three children, the most talented, the most deprived, or the one who inherited it, coded as talent, need, and inheritance (Appendix B).

Political self-placement (0 to 10, far left to far right) is elicited at the end of the outcome block rather than before treatment, to avoid priming. It is therefore post-treatment, and we use it only descriptively and in the propensity model of Appendix D, where excluding it and the other post-treatment items strengthens the backfire estimate.

The block also contains a dictator game and, at the end of the survey, two knowledge questions on the 2022 inflation rate overall and for low-income singles, the statistics reported in the left-leaning article, and a question on the perceived political slant of the survey. The knowledge questions serve as a manipulation check and as a belief-updating measure (Section 8); wording for all items is in Appendix B.

3.4 Covariates

After the outcome block we elicit media consumption, main and secondary news source among broadcast and print, online portals, and social media, with outlet-level indicators within each, and socio-demographic characteristics (education, income, marital status, religion, region of birth, employment, home ownership, parental education and birth region) together with the 2021 federal vote. These variables are elicited after treatment but describe characteristics and habits that predate it, so treatment is unlikely to move them, although a recalled vote can drift (Section 4.1); they serve as controls and, together with the dissonance and justice items, as candidate predictors in Appendix D.

4 Data, Balance and Descriptives

4.1 Balance and Representativeness

Table C.1 reports means of the stratification variables, socio-economic characteristics, 2021 vote and the justice question by arm, with p-values for the difference between each treatment arm and the control group. Of the 120 pairwise comparisons, four are nominally significant at the 5% level (age 35–44 and Catholic affiliation in T3; age 65+ and household income above €6,000 in T2), roughly the number expected by chance, and none survives the Romano–Wolf correction in the last column. Justice orientations, elicited by the flute question (Sen, 2009), are likewise balanced (43% allocate to the child in need, 28% to the most talented, 21% to the heir). An omnibus multinomial logit of arm assignment on all covariates does not reject balance (likelihood-ratio $\chi^2(162) = 182.7$, $p = 0.13$); arm-specific joint F-tests are marginal for T2 ($p = 0.005$) and T3 ($p = 0.02$), reflecting the same few small differences. Since assignment was block-randomized by the survey provider, these are chance imbalances; all specifications include the full covariate set, and Section 7 shows that results are insensitive to it.

The sample is a quota sample, not a probability sample, and column (5) shows where it departs from the SOEP (2022) population benchmarks. Education and gender match closely. The age distribution is compressed toward the middle: respondents aged 18–24 (10% vs. 17%) and 65+ (12% vs. 21%) are under-represented, and full-time employment is over-represented (54% vs. 37%). Protestants are under-represented (16% vs. 33%). Table C.3 reports estimates reweighted to these margins; the main results are unaffected.

Reported 2021 voting departs from the official result in one dimension: 17.6% of party voters report having voted AfD, against an actual 10.4%, while non-voters are under-represented (15% vs. 23%). Two explanations are plausible and not mutually exclusive. The panel may over-sample AfD supporters. Alternatively, recall of a vote cast three years earlier may drift toward current preference: the survey was fielded between December 2024 and February 2025, during the campaign for the federal election of 23 February 2025 in which the AfD obtained 20.8%, and the sample share lies between the 2021 and 2025 results. Because the 2021 vote enters only as a control and as a descriptive split, neither explanation affects the treatment estimates; for external validity, Table C.3 reweights the sample to each benchmark, an AfD share of 10.4% (2021) and of 20.8% (2025).

4.2 Baseline Preferences for Redistribution

Figure 2 shows the control-group distribution of the six policy outcomes. Three features matter for reading the treatment effects. First, support is not uniform across instruments: a minimum-wage increase draws near-consensus (80% at 6 or above; 35% at the maximum), the wealth tax a clear majority (65%), and universal basic income a divided public (57% at 6 or above, but 35% at 4 or below), so UBI is the most polarized of the three agreement items and the one

with the most room to move in either direction. Second, the two slider outcomes carry a large mass at the status quo (30% for corporate tax, 19% for inheritance tax), and the inheritance-tax distribution leans toward *reduction* (45% below the status quo vs. 37% above), so the positive left-article effect on inheritance tax in Table 3 moves respondents from a baseline that favors cutting the tax. Third, the preferred top income-tax rate has a median of 38% (interquartile range 28–50%) against the 27% anchor given for a minimum-wage earner. Because outcomes are standardized to the control group, the standard deviations reported in Figure 2 are the units of the effect sizes in Section 6.

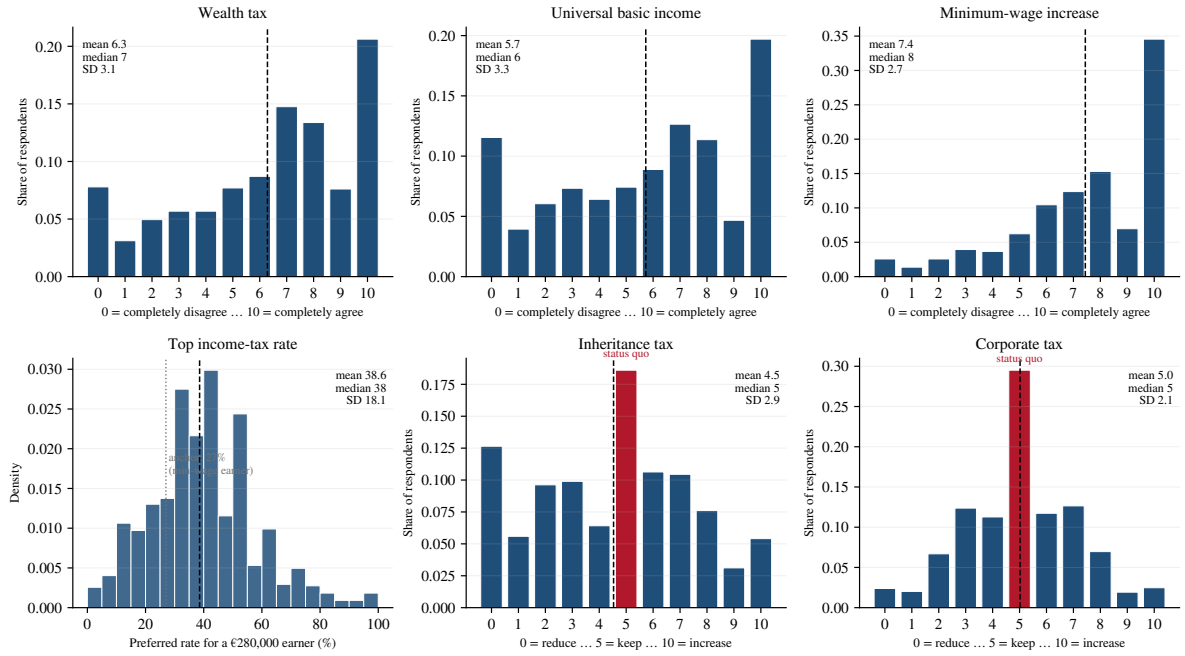


Figure 2. Distribution of the six redistributive-policy outcomes in the control group. Dashed line: mean. The top income-tax question is anchored on the information that a minimum-wage earner pays about 27%; the inheritance- and corporate-tax sliders are centered on the current rate (status quo = 5). N = 1,091.

4.3 Perceived Inflation

At the end of the survey respondents were asked for the 2022 inflation rate overall and for low-income singles, the two statistics on which the left article rests. Figure 3 reports control-group answers by household income. Two facts stand out. Perceptions are, at the median, accurate and flat across income: 6.9–7.0% in every income group against an official 7.9%, and 7.0–8.2% for low-income singles against the Böckler Foundation's 10.7%. Means tell a different story only because of a thin right tail of implausible answers (3% of respondents report rates above 50%), which is heavier among low-income respondents and generates a spurious income gradient in the mean. We therefore use medians, or means winsorized at 50%, throughout. These two questions also serve as the post-treatment belief measures in Section 8.

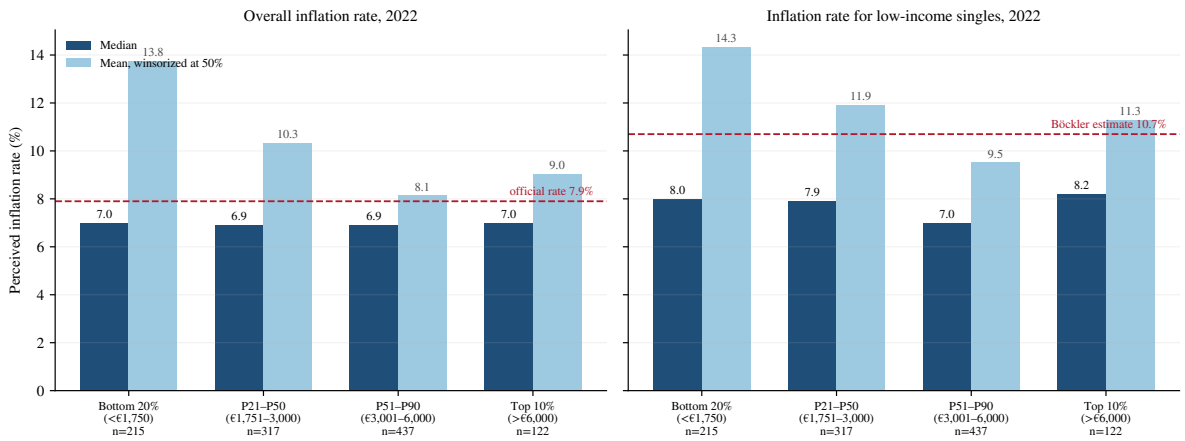


Figure 3. Perceived 2022 inflation by household income, control group. Dark bars: medians; light bars: means after winsorizing at 50%. Dashed lines: the official overall rate (7.9%) and the Böckler Foundation estimate for low-income singles (10.7%) cited in the left article.

5 Empirical Strategy

5.1 Estimating Equations

Assignment to the four arms is random, so differences in outcomes across arms are causal. Our baseline specification estimates intent-to-treat effects by arm,

$$Y_i = \alpha + \beta_1 \, \mathrm{T1}_i + \beta_2 \, \mathrm{T2}_i + \beta_3 \, \mathrm{T3}_i + X_i'\gamma + \varepsilon_i, \tag{7}$$

where Y_i is an outcome, $\mathrm{T1}_i$–$\mathrm{T3}_i$ are assignment indicators with the no-article control as the omitted category, and X_i collects the stratification variables (age, gender, education) and the socio-demographic controls listed in Section 3.4. The coefficients β_1–β_3 are the effects of being *offered* each arm.

Because T2 and T3 record what respondents chose, we also estimate the decomposed specification

$$Y_i = \alpha + \beta_1 \, \mathrm{T1}_i + \beta_{2r} \, \mathrm{T2}_i^{\mathrm{read}} + \beta_{2s} \, \mathrm{T2}_i^{\mathrm{skip}} + \beta_{3\ell} \, \mathrm{T3}_i^{\mathrm{left}} + \beta_{3r} \, \mathrm{T3}_i^{\mathrm{right}} + X_i'\gamma + \varepsilon_i, \tag{8}$$

which splits T2 by whether the article was opened and T3 by which article was chosen. The interpretation differs across coefficients and we are explicit about it. β_1 is the causal effect of exposure to the left article on a randomly assigned population. β_{2r}, β_{2s}, $\beta_{3\ell}$ and β_{3r} condition on a post-assignment choice. For a group defined by its choice c, the coefficient is $\beta_c = \big(\mathbb{E}[y_i^0 \mid c] - \mathbb{E}[y_i^0]\big) + \mathbb{E}[y_i - y_i^0 \mid c]$: where the group started relative to the population, plus how far it moved (Appendix E.6). These coefficients describe what a fragmented environment delivers, the position of those who seek out or avoid a narrative relative to everyone else, and β_1 is the benchmark of the same content without selection. A gap between $\beta_{3\ell}$ and β_1, however, can arise from the first term alone, so it does not show that reading by choice moves people more.

The causal comparisons are between assigned arms. Because only respondents offered the left article can read it, assignment to T2 is an instrument for reading with one-sided noncompliance. If seeing the headline alone does not move those who decline, the T2 intent-to-treat effect divided by the share who read (87%) is the effect of reading on those who read when offered; if, in addition, imposing the article affects them as reading it voluntarily does, the difference between the T1 and T2 intent-to-treat effects, divided by the share who decline (13%), is the effect of forced exposure on those who would decline (Gaines and Kuklinski, 2011). In the choice arm, the coefficients of the two groups, weighted by their shares, sum to the arm's intent-to-treat effect up to the controls, and selection cancels from that sum. Their unweighted sum $\beta_{3\ell} + \beta_{3r}$, reported in Table 4, does not have this property: with 43% choosing the left article it differs from zero even if neither article moves anyone, so we report it as a description of how the two groups of choosers differ from the control group, not as a test of whether the articles have mirror-image effects.

5.2 Outcomes and Scaling

The six policy outcomes are standardized to the control group (mean zero, standard deviation one), so coefficients are effect sizes in control-group standard-deviation units and are comparable across instruments with different scales. The redistribution index is the first principal component of the six standardized items, rescaled the same way; it explains 37.7% of their variance with all loadings positive. Platform outcomes are indicators for ranking a platform first, estimated by linear probability models with coefficients in percentage points; probit average marginal effects are reported as a check.

5.3 Inference

Standard errors are clustered at the federal-state level ($G = 16$). Because asymptotic cluster-robust inference is unreliable with this few clusters, every headline coefficient is accompanied by a wild-cluster bootstrap-t p-value with the null imposed and Webb six-point weights (Cameron et al., 2008); Table 7 reports both. For the six policy outcomes we control the family-wise error rate within each treatment across the six tests using the Romano and Wolf (2005) step-down procedure with 1,000 cluster-bootstrap replications, and report unadjusted and adjusted p-values side by side.

The registration (AEARCTR-0014878) was submitted on 25 November and published on 3 December 2024, nine days before fielding began. It names preferences for redistributive policies as the primary outcome; states two directional hypotheses, that information on the regressive incidence of inflation increases support for redistribution, and that information on the growth costs of redistribution lowers it; and targets roughly 5,000 respondents, powered to detect 0.1 SD at 80% (the realized analysis sample is 4,524). It fixes no multiple-testing families and no secondary outcomes.

The tests of these hypotheses are the intent-to-treat effects of (7), by assigned arm, on the six policy outcomes, with the family-wise error rate controlled across the six within each arm; Table 1 reports them with cluster-robust, wild-cluster bootstrap and Romano–Wolf p-values. Two features of the design shape what these tests can establish. The registered primary outcome is described as a 0–10 agreement scale, which three of the six items are; the preferred top income-tax rate and the inheritance- and corporate-tax sliders use other scales, and standardizing all six to the control group is what allows them to enter a single family. And only the first hypothesis has a clean intent-to-treat test. The forced and optional arms deliver only the left article; the growth article appears only in the choice arm, where it is selected rather than assigned, so the second hypothesis can be evaluated only through the choice arm's intent-to-treat effect, which mixes the two articles, or through coefficients that bundle exposure with selection (Section 5.1).

The registration fixes the design, the primary outcome and the two hypotheses. It does not specify the analyses that the optional and choice arms make possible, and much of the paper rests on them: the redistribution index; the decomposition of T2 by whether the article was opened and of T3 by which article was chosen; the model of article choice, including the LASSO propensity score and the heterogeneity analysis built on it; and the $\hat{\lambda}$ estimates of belief updating. These analyses were not pre-specified. They follow from the registered design, which includes the optional and choice arms in order to observe what respondents decide to read, and we report them with the same inference as the registered tests: cluster-robust standard errors, wild-cluster bootstrap p-values for the main coefficients, and Romano–Wolf adjustment across the six policy outcomes. The intent-to-treat effects on the index (Table 2, column 1) summarize the outcome-level effects in Table 1; the conclusions on the comparison of forced, voluntary and chosen exposure, on backfire, and on belief updating rest on the analyses beyond the registration.

5.4 Heterogeneity and Backfire

Prediction P3 concerns respondents for whom the left article is incongruent. We proxy congruence with $\hat{p}_i$, the predicted probability of choosing the right article, obtained in two steps: an ℓ_1-penalized logit of right-article choice on 77 candidate predictors (stratification and socio-demographic variables, the 2021 vote, political self-placement, media consumption, the three cognitive-dissonance items and the justice question), estimated on the choice arm with the penalty chosen by 5-fold cross-validation, retains 16 predictors; an unpenalized logit on those 16, again estimated on the choice arm, is then applied to every respondent (Appendix D). The fitted score has a cross-validated AUC of 0.63: it predicts choice, but coarsely, so it should be read as a noisy proxy for ideological alignment. Because T1 is randomly assigned, the interaction $\mathrm{T1}_i \times \hat{p}_i$ in (8), and the corresponding quintile interactions, estimate how the effect of forced exposure varies with $\hat{p}_i$, provided the predictors are not themselves moved by treatment. Three caveats apply. First, five predictors (the three dissonance items, the justice question and

self-placement) were elicited after treatment. The justice question and $\hat{p}_i$ itself are balanced across the randomized arms (Table C.1; Appendix D), and excluding all five predictors from the score strengthens the backfire estimate rather than weakening it (Appendix D). Second, $\hat{p}_i$ is fitted on the choice arm, so for the forced-exposure and control respondents, whose comparison identifies the interaction, it is an out-of-sample prediction. Third, measurement error in $\hat{p}_i$ attenuates the interaction, so the backfire estimates are conservative.

5.5 Belief Updating

The knowledge questions at the end of the survey elicit the factual beliefs on which the left article rests, and the control group's answer is the counterfactual prior under random assignment. For each arm we estimate the updating weight of (3) as $\hat{\lambda} = (\text{posterior} - \text{prior})/(\text{signal} - \text{prior})$, with medians in place of means because a thin right tail of implausible answers dominates the latter, and cluster-bootstrap confidence intervals. The questions are unincentivized and come a few minutes after the article, so $\hat{\lambda}$ measures how far reported beliefs move, which may reflect recall as well as acceptance (Section 8.3). Arms that never saw a statistic serve as placebos. $\hat{\lambda}$ is a group-level quantity; individual dissonance costs are not identified in this wave (Section 2.7).

6 Results

We present results in the order of the three predictions: who chooses which article (Prediction P1), how exposure moves preferences (Prediction P2), and where forced exposure backfires (Prediction P3). Throughout, policy outcomes and the index are in control-group standard-deviation units and platform outcomes in percentage points.

6.1 Selective Exposure

In the choice arm, 57% of respondents open the right (growth) article. Choice is confirmatory (Figure 4): among respondents who voted for a right-of-center party in 2021 the share is 67% (CDU/CSU), 65% (AfD) and 61% (FDP); among left-of-center voters it is 52% (Linke), 49% (SPD) and 48% (Greens). The share rises by 5 percentage points per step of political self-placement ($p < 0.001$) and is unaffected by the order in which the two headlines were shown (a recency effect of about 3 points). This is Prediction P1: at the point of choice, the cost of exposure outweighs the value of information, given that the two articles are expected to be equally accurate (Section 2.3).

Who selects is predicted by partisanship and media diet, not by psychological disposition. Of 77 candidate predictors, the LASSO retains 16 (Table D.1): readers of *Bild*, *Welt* and Yahoo News, full-time employees and CDU/CSU voters are more likely to choose the growth article; SPD voters, respondents who place themselves on the left, those aged 25–34, and users of

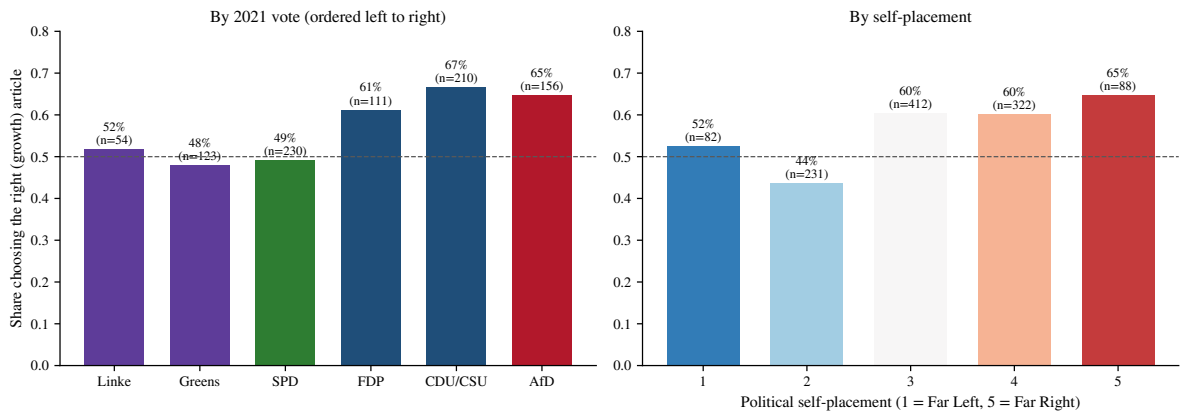


Figure 4. Article choice in the choice arm (T3). Share of respondents choosing the right (growth) article by 2021 vote and by political self-placement. Right-leaning respondents choose the congenial article more often.

Instagram, Snapchat and TikTok are less likely. None of the three cognitive-dissonance items and neither the justice question nor education is retained. The fitted model predicts choice only coarsely (cross-validated AUC 0.63), which is itself informative: most of the variation in what people choose to read is not explained by who they are on observables.

Engagement with the content does not depend on whether it was chosen. In the optional arm 87% open the article. Asked afterwards whether they would share it, 42% of forced readers and 45% of voluntary readers say yes, as do 46% of those who chose the left article in T3; among those who chose the right article the share is 36%.

6.2 The Registered Tests

Table 1 reports the tests of the registered hypotheses: the intent-to-treat effect of each assigned arm on the six policy outcomes. The first hypothesis is borne out. Being offered the left article (T2) raises support for the wealth tax by 0.15 SD, the inheritance tax by 0.13 SD and the corporate tax by 0.17 SD, and all three effects survive both few-cluster inference (bootstrap $p \leq 0.006$) and adjustment for the six outcomes (Romano–Wolf $p \leq 0.009$). Forced exposure (T1) moves the same three taxes in the same direction, but only its effect on the corporate tax (0.17 SD) survives all three procedures (Romano–Wolf $p = 0.062$); its other effects are smaller than the 0.1 SD the design was powered to detect. Neither arm moves support for a universal basic income or the preferred top income-tax rate, and the effect on the minimum wage, which the article also proposes, is 0.05 SD and does not survive adjustment. What the left article raises is support for taxing wealth and capital, not support for redistribution across the board.

The choice arm mixes readers of both articles. It raises support for the wealth and inheritance taxes and lowers support for a universal basic income (−0.10 SD, bootstrap $p = 0.053$), though none of its effects survives the adjustment. That negative effect is the only intent-to-treat evidence bearing on the second hypothesis: neither arm that delivers only the left article moves

UBI, which points to the growth article, the one that attacks the citizen's allowance by name, as its source.

The registered arms do not by themselves rank voluntary above forced exposure. Offering the article raises support for the wealth tax by 0.10 SD more than imposing it (bootstrap $p = 0.018$), but the difference does not survive the adjustment and is indistinguishable from zero on the other five outcomes and on the index (Panel C). The ordering reported below, forced < voluntary < chosen, therefore concerns who chooses to read rather than the effect of being offered a choice; it is the exposure-plus-selection bundle that the decomposition of the optional and choice arms is designed to measure (Section 5.1).

6.3 Effects on the Redistribution Index

Table 2 reports effects on the redistribution index; Figure 5 plots the decomposed specification. Every arm that delivers the left article raises support for redistribution. As intent-to-treat effects, forced exposure raises the index by 0.10 SD, the optional arm by 0.15 SD and the choice arm, which mixes readers of both articles, by 0.06 SD (column 1). In the decomposition (column 2), forced readers end 0.10 SD above the control group, voluntary readers 0.19 SD and respondents who chose the left article 0.27 SD, all significant at 5% or better, while those who chose the right article end 0.09 SD below ($p = 0.025$). Only the first of these is a causal effect; the others add to the effect of reading the difference in where each group started (Section 5.1). Respondents who skip the article in T2 are not different from the control group (−0.09 SD, $p = 0.26$). The equal-weight index gives the same pattern (column 3).

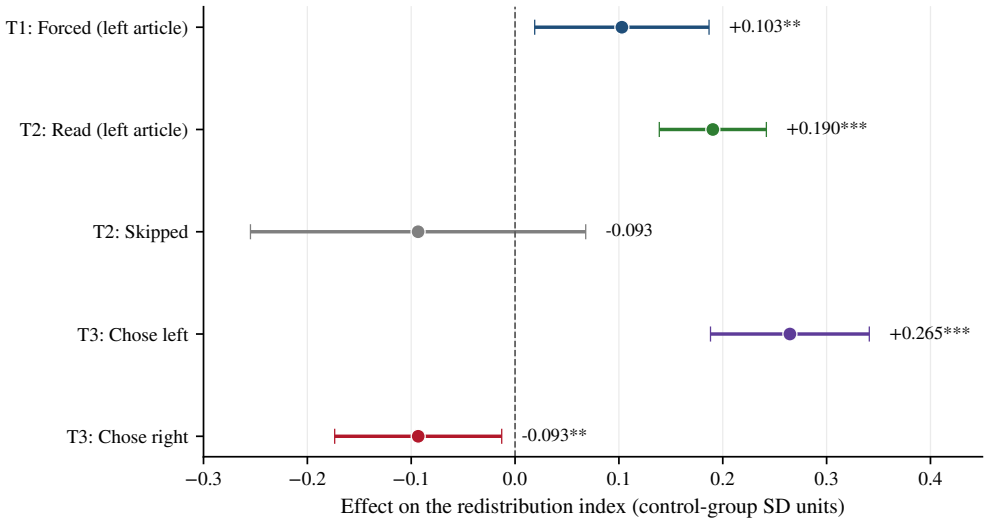


Figure 5. The redistribution index by arm and, within T2 and T3, by choice. Point estimates and 95% confidence intervals from the decomposed specification (Table 2, column 2). Only T1 is a randomized contrast; the other coefficients combine the effect of reading with selection (Section 5.1). Standard errors clustered at the federal-state level ($G = 16$).

Two qualifications matter for how much weight each coefficient can bear. First, the voluntary

Table 1. Registered hypotheses: intent-to-treat effects on the six policy outcomes

	Wealth tax (1)	UBI (2)	Min. wage (3)	Income tax (4)	Inheritance tax (5)	Corporate tax (6)
Panel A: Intent-to-treat effects by assigned arm (control-group SD units)						
T1: Forced (left article)	0.051	-0.022	0.049*	0.003	0.087**	0.165***
	(0.034)	(0.026)	(0.027)	(0.063)	(0.040)	(0.043)
T2: Optional (left article)	0.150***	-0.037	0.054*	0.016	0.129***	0.173***
	(0.030)	(0.027)	(0.029)	(0.029)	(0.032)	(0.039)
T3: Choice (left or right)	0.091***	-0.096**	-0.010	0.004	0.106***	0.057
	(0.033)	(0.041)	(0.038)	(0.040)	(0.035)	(0.042)
Panel B: p-values — cluster-robust, few-cluster robust, and adjusted for six outcomes						
T1 Forced – cluster-robust p	0.135	0.391	0.074	0.957	0.030	0.000
wild-cluster bootstrap p	0.265	0.385	0.106	0.963	**0.063**	**0.006**
Romano–Wolf p	0.428	0.670	0.345	0.955	0.278	**0.062**
T2 Optional – cluster-robust p	0.000	0.171	0.060	0.572	0.000	0.000
wild-cluster bootstrap p	**0.001**	0.189	**0.069**	0.588	**0.006**	**0.000**
Romano–Wolf p	**0.005**	0.272	0.219	0.578	**0.009**	**0.009**
T3 Choice – cluster-robust p	0.006	0.020	0.802	0.915	0.002	0.178
wild-cluster bootstrap p	**0.010**	**0.053**	0.813	0.924	**0.038**	0.217
Romano–Wolf p	0.213	0.271	0.959	0.959	0.175	0.515
Panel C: Offering versus imposing the left article (a contrast between randomized arms, not a registered hypothesis)						
T2 − T1	0.099**	-0.015	0.005	0.013	0.042	0.008
	(0.044)	(0.031)	(0.028)	(0.055)	(0.040)	(0.038)
wild-cluster bootstrap p	**0.018**	0.689	0.845	0.823	0.304	0.844
Romano–Wolf p	0.251	0.971	0.994	0.994	0.786	0.994
Control-group mean (raw scale)	6.29	5.73	7.44	38.59	4.53	5.02
Control-group SD (raw scale)	3.13	3.34	2.66	18.14	2.87	2.08
Observations	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524
Adjusted R^2	0.121	0.088	0.141	0.059	0.126	0.058

Notes: The pre-registration (AEARCTR-0014878) names preferences for redistributive policies as the primary outcome and states two directional hypotheses. The table reports the intent-to-treat specification (7), by assigned arm, on the six policy outcomes. T1 and T2 deliver only the left article and test the first hypothesis, that information on the regressive incidence of inflation raises support for redistribution. T3 offers a choice between the two articles, so its intent-to-treat effect mixes them and carries no single registered prediction; the second hypothesis, on the growth article, has no intent-to-treat test because that article is never assigned (Section 5.3). Panel B reports, for each arm, the cluster-robust p-value, the wild-cluster bootstrap-t p-value (Webb weights, null imposed, 4,999 replications), and the Romano–Wolf (2005) step-down p-value controlling the family-wise error rate across the six outcomes within the arm (1,000 cluster-bootstrap replications); bold: $p < 0.10$; all tests two-sided. Panel C reports the difference between the optional and the forced arm, both of which deliver only the left article; it is a contrast between randomized arms rather than a registered hypothesis, and its p-values are computed in the same three ways. On the redistribution index the same difference is 0.051 (0.047), wild-cluster bootstrap $p = 0.303$. Outcomes are standardized to the control group (mean 0, SD 1), so coefficients are effect sizes in control-group standard-deviation units. Standard errors clustered at the federal-state level ($G = 16$) in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$. All specifications include stratification and demographic controls (nationality, age, gender, education, household income, marital status, religion, place of birth, employment, housing tenure, income source, and 2021 vote). Omitted category: no-article control group.

Table 2. The redistribution index: intent-to-treat effects and coefficients by choice (control-group SD units)

	Redistribution index (PC1)		Equal-weight z-index
	(1) Pooled arms	(2) Decomposed arms	(3) Decomposed arms
T1: Forced (left article)	0.103**	0.103**	0.094**
	(0.043)	(0.043)	(0.043)
T2: Optional	0.154***		
	(0.025)		
T2: Read (left article)		0.190***	0.176***
		(0.026)	(0.026)
T2: Skipped		-0.093	-0.126
		(0.082)	(0.088)
T3: Choice	0.062**		
	(0.032)		
T3: Chose left		0.265***	0.251***
		(0.039)	(0.041)
T3: Chose right		-0.093**	-0.114***
		(0.041)	(0.042)
Observations	4,524	4,524	4,524
Adjusted R^2	0.126	0.136	0.132

Notes: The redistribution index is the first principal component of the six standardized policy outcomes (PC1 explains 37.7% of the variance; all six loadings positive, range 0.28 - 0.51), rescaled to mean 0 and SD 1 in the control group; column (3) applies the same rescaling to the equal-weighted average of the six z-scores. Column (1) pools each arm; columns (2) and (3) decompose T2 by whether the respondent read or skipped the article and T3 by which article was chosen. Standard errors clustered at the federal-state level ($G = 16$) in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$. All specifications include stratification and demographic controls (nationality, age, gender, education, household income, marital status, religion, place of birth, employment, housing tenure, income source, and 2021 vote). Omitted category: no-article control group.

and directional effects are robust to few-cluster inference: the wild-cluster bootstrap p-values for T2-read and T3-left are below 0.001 (Table 7, Panel B). The forced-exposure effect is not: its bootstrap p-value is 0.14, and that of T3-right is 0.08. We therefore read the T1 and T3-right index coefficients as suggestive. The ordering forced < voluntary < chosen survives this inference, but it is descriptive: it contains a selection term (Section 5.1) and does not show that choice amplifies persuasion. Second, among respondents who passed the attention check on the first attempt the point estimates are unchanged but T3-right loses precision (−0.11 SD, $p = 0.11$; Table 6, Panel A).

6.4 Narrative-Specific Effects

The index conceals which policies move. Table 3 and Figure 6 show which instruments move with each article: for the left article, the taxes on wealth and capital rather than every instrument it proposes; for the right article, a basic income and the minimum wage, neither of which it mentions. Readers of the left article, which proposes a wealth tax, an excess-profits tax and a higher minimum wage, report more support than the control group for the wealth tax (0.16 SD when read voluntarily, 0.24 SD when chosen), the inheritance tax, which the article does not mention (0.16 and 0.21 SD), and the corporate tax (0.20 and 0.23 SD). These six coefficients survive Romano–Wolf correction across the six outcomes ($p \leq 0.034$; Panel B); the minimum wage, which the article does propose, moves less (0.09 and 0.12 SD). Respondents who chose the right article, which attacks the citizen's allowance and argues for tax cuts, report support for a universal basic income 0.20 SD below the control group (Romano–Wolf $p = 0.051$) and for a minimum-wage increase 0.11 SD below ($p = 0.113$ after correction). No arm moves the preferred top income-tax rate. Forced exposure, the one causal estimate in the table, moves the corporate tax (0.17 SD, corrected $p = 0.061$) and little else.

The skippers in T2 are the mirror image of the readers. They are not moved by an article they did not open, yet they report lower support for UBI (−0.18 SD) and the minimum wage (−0.18 SD) than the control group. Since assignment to T2 is random, this is selection: respondents who decline the left article are less sympathetic than the population to transfers and to a higher minimum wage. Its sign is the one a cost of exposure predicts, and the opposite of what an accuracy motive alone would produce if all respondents weighed accuracy and trusted the article alike (Appendix E.6).

6.5 Two Asymmetries: Policy Moves Left, Politics Moves Right

Table 4 adds the coefficients of the two groups of choosers in T3. The sum is not a test of whether the two articles are mirror images, since it differs from zero under selection alone (Section 5.1), but it shows which group departs further from the control group, and the answer differs between policy and party. On *policy*, those who chose the left article depart further: the sum is +0.17 SD on the index ($p = 0.006$), +0.22 on the wealth tax ($p = 0.001$) and +0.24 on the inheritance

Table 3. Six redistributive-policy outcomes: coefficients by arm and choice

	Wealth tax (1)	UBI (2)	Min. wage (3)	Income tax (4)	Inheritance tax (5)	Corporate tax (6)
Panel A: OLS coefficients (control-group SD units)						
T1: Forced (left article)	0.051	-0.022	0.049*	0.003	0.087**	0.165***
	(0.034)	(0.026)	(0.027)	(0.063)	(0.040)	(0.043)
T2: Read (left article)	0.164***	-0.015	0.088***	0.025	0.163***	0.198***
	(0.033)	(0.023)	(0.030)	(0.032)	(0.042)	(0.040)
T2: Skipped	0.056	-0.185*	-0.176**	-0.046	-0.104	0.000
	(0.074)	(0.109)	(0.089)	(0.069)	(0.078)	(0.081)
T3: Chose left	0.235***	0.036	0.117*	0.058	0.214***	0.227***
	(0.038)	(0.053)	(0.062)	(0.066)	(0.032)	(0.047)
T3: Chose right	-0.020	-0.198***	-0.107***	-0.037	0.024	-0.073
	(0.038)	(0.047)	(0.034)	(0.030)	(0.046)	(0.048)
Panel B: Multiple-testing adjustment (p-values)						
T1 Forced – unadjusted p	0.135	0.396	0.073	0.956	0.029	0.000
Romano–Wolf p	0.425	0.672	0.344	0.953	0.278	**0.061**
T2 Read – unadjusted p	0.000	0.527	0.003	0.432	0.000	0.000
Romano–Wolf p	**0.003**	0.571	**0.027**	0.571	**0.010**	**0.003**
T3 Left – unadjusted p	0.000	0.490	0.058	0.374	0.000	0.000
Romano–Wolf p	**0.015**	0.650	0.325	0.650	**0.012**	**0.034**
T3 Right – unadjusted p	0.595	0.000	0.001	0.205	0.606	0.125
Romano–Wolf p	0.815	**0.051**	0.113	0.523	0.815	0.523
Control-group mean (raw scale)	6.29	5.73	7.44	38.59	4.53	5.02
Control-group SD (raw scale)	3.13	3.34	2.66	18.14	2.87	2.08
Observations	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524
Adjusted R^2	0.125	0.092	0.146	0.059	0.130	0.064

Notes: Outcomes are standardized to the control group (mean 0, SD 1), so coefficients are effect sizes in control-group standard-deviation units. Raw scales: wealth tax, UBI and minimum wage are 0–10 agreement scales; income tax is the preferred top rate in percent (0–100); inheritance and corporate taxes are slider responses (higher = more redistribution); raw control-group means and SDs are reported in the footer. Panel B reports, for each treatment, the unadjusted p-value and the Romano–Wolf (2005) step-down p-value controlling the family-wise error rate across the six outcomes (1,000 cluster-bootstrap replications; bold: adjusted $p < 0.10$); p-values are invariant to the standardization. T2 Skipped is omitted from Panel B because of its small cell ($n = 149$). Standard errors clustered at the federal-state level ($G = 16$) in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$. All specifications include stratification and demographic controls (nationality, age, gender, education, household income, marital status, religion, place of birth, employment, housing tenure, income source, and 2021 vote). Omitted category: no-article control group.

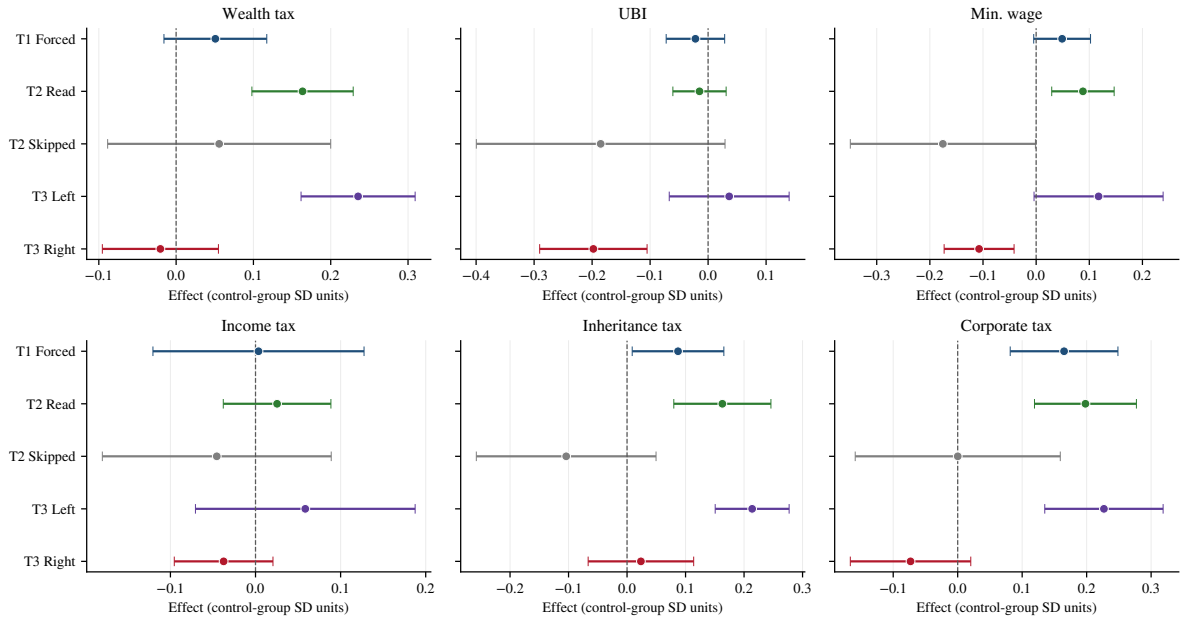


Figure 6. Six redistributive-policy outcomes by arm and choice. Coefficients from Table 3, Panel A, in control-group standard-deviation units; 95% confidence intervals. Only T1 is a randomized contrast; the other coefficients combine the effect of reading with selection (Section 5.1).

tax ($p < 0.001$), while on UBI those who chose the right article do (-0.16, $p = 0.057$) and on the minimum wage neither group does. On *party* preference the pattern runs the other way. Table 5 and Figure 7 report effects on ranking each platform first. Respondents who chose the right article are 3.8 points more likely to rank the far-right platform first ($p < 0.01$). The gain is not specific to that article: forced exposure to the left article raises the far-right share by 2.5 points ($p < 0.05$), and voluntary readers of the left article rank the far-right platform first 3.2 points more often ($p < 0.10$). Those who chose the left article do not rank either left platform first more often (2.3 and 1.8 points, neither significant); their only significant coefficient on party preference is on the Center-Right platform, which they rank first 4.0 points less often ($p < 0.05$), as do voluntary readers in T2 (-3.0 points).

The left article therefore moves policy preferences without moving votes to the left platforms, while the far-right platform gains whichever article is read. Section 8.2 interprets the first pattern through the bundling of fiscal and migration positions in the platforms and discusses the second.

6.6 Backfire

Prediction P3 asks whether forced exposure moves the respondents least disposed to the left article *against* it. Figure 8 interacts forced exposure with the right-leaning propensity $\hat{p}_i$. On the index and on every tax-the-rich policy the interaction is indistinguishable from zero: right-leaning respondents forced to read the article do not lower their support for redistribution as a whole. On UBI it is negative, -0.34 SD per unit of $\hat{p}_i$ ($p = 0.064$; $p = 0.015$ and 0.014 under the alternative penalty rules reported in Table C.4). Figure 9 shows the shape of the

Table 4. Sum of the coefficients of the two groups of choosers in T3

Outcome	$\hat{\beta}_L$	$\hat{\beta}_R$	$\hat{\beta}_L + \hat{\beta}_R$	(SE)	F	p
Redistribution index	0.265	-0.093	0.171	(0.062)	7.66	0.006***
Wealth tax	0.235	-0.020	0.215	(0.065)	10.85	0.001***
UBI	0.036	-0.198	-0.161	(0.085)	3.61	0.057*
Min. wage	0.117	-0.107	0.010	(0.081)	0.02	0.901
Income tax	0.058	-0.037	0.021	(0.083)	0.06	0.801
Inheritance tax	0.214	0.024	0.238	(0.066)	13.15	0.000***
Corporate tax	0.227	-0.073	0.154	(0.087)	3.13	0.077*
Left (π)	2.33	-1.53	0.80	(3.02)	0.07	0.791
Center-Left (θ)	1.78	-2.37	-0.59	(2.25)	0.07	0.793
Center-Right (ω)	-3.96	-0.98	-4.94	(3.16)	2.45	0.118
Far-Right (σ)	1.31	3.77	5.08	(2.61)	3.77	0.052*
Restrictive-migration bundle ($\omega \cup \sigma$)	-2.65	2.78	0.14	(2.82)	0.00	0.962

Notes: Wald test of $H_0 : \beta_L + \beta_R = 0$ on the coefficients for respondents who chose the left and the right article in the decomposed specification. Each coefficient adds a selection term to the effect of reading (Section 5.1), and the two groups differ in size (43% and 57% of the arm), so the sum differs from zero even if neither article moves anyone; it is not a test of whether the two articles have mirror-image effects. When the two coefficients have opposite signs, a positive sum means that those who chose the left article depart further from the control group than those who chose the right article. The share-weighted sum, from which selection cancels, is the choice arm's intent-to-treat effect (Table 2, column 1; Table 1). Index and policy outcomes in control-group SD units; platform outcomes in percentage points. F is the clustered Wald statistic with one restriction. Standard errors clustered at the federal-state level ($G = 16$) in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$. All specifications include stratification and demographic controls (nationality, age, gender, education, household income, marital status, religion, place of birth, employment, housing tenure, income source, and 2021 vote). Omitted category: no-article control group.

Table 5. Marginal effects on political-platform choice

	Top-ranked platform				Bundle
	Left (π)	Center-Left (θ)	Center-Right (ω)	Far-Right (σ)	Restrictive migration
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
T1: Forced (left article)	1.87	-1.73	-1.39	2.45**	1.06
	(1.59)	(1.46)	(1.35)	(1.07)	(1.16)
T2: Read (left article)	0.30	2.04	-3.04**	3.21*	0.17
	(2.10)	(1.85)	(1.45)	(1.73)	(1.26)
T2: Skipped	-3.53	2.49	-2.76	1.90	-0.86
	(2.53)	(2.71)	(4.18)	(2.38)	(3.98)
T3: Chose left	2.33	1.78	-3.96**	1.31	-2.65
	(1.98)	(1.92)	(1.77)	(1.84)	(1.61)
T3: Chose right	-1.53	-2.37*	-0.98	3.77***	2.78
	(1.57)	(1.38)	(1.90)	(1.17)	(1.69)
Control-group share (%)	11.5	21.8	31.8	25.6	57.4
Observations	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524

Notes: Linear probability models; coefficients are marginal effects in percentage points on the probability of ranking the platform first. Platforms bundle a fiscal and a migration position: π = open borders and radical redistribution; θ = inclusive migration and progressive taxation; ω = selective skilled migration and moderate tax cuts; σ = strict migration controls and corporate tax cuts. Column (5) is an indicator for top-ranking either restrictive-migration platform. Probit average marginal effects are reported in Table 7. Standard errors clustered at the federal-state level ($G = 16$) in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$. All specifications include stratification and demographic controls (nationality, age, gender, education, household income, marital status, religion, place of birth, employment, housing tenure, income source, and 2021 vote). Omitted category: no-article control group.

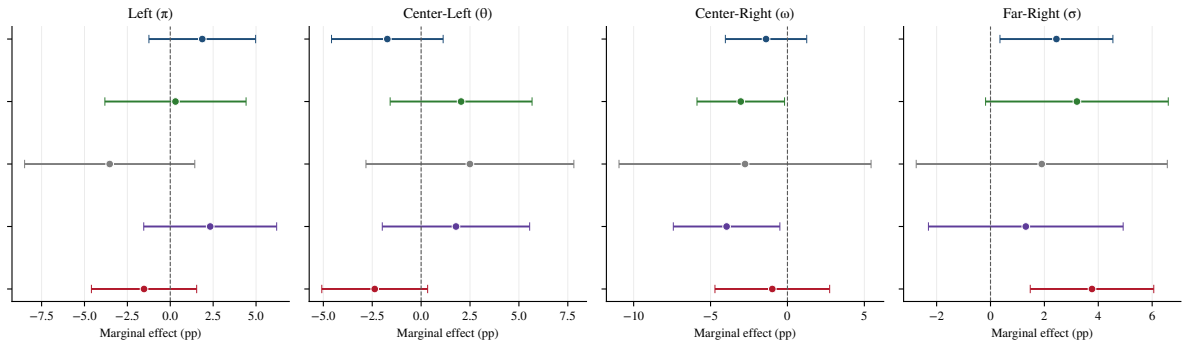


Figure 7. Marginal effects on political-platform choice. Linear-probability estimates in percentage points (Table 5); 95% confidence intervals.

effect: forced exposure raises UBI support by 0.12 SD in the most left-leaning fifth ($p < 0.05$) and lowers it by 0.18 SD in the most right-leaning fifth ($p < 0.01$), with the middle quintiles near zero. The same article pushes the two ends of the distribution apart on the one policy that is most contested, and nowhere else. The far-right platform shows no such heterogeneity ($p = 0.47$). None of these interactions is adjusted for testing across outcomes.

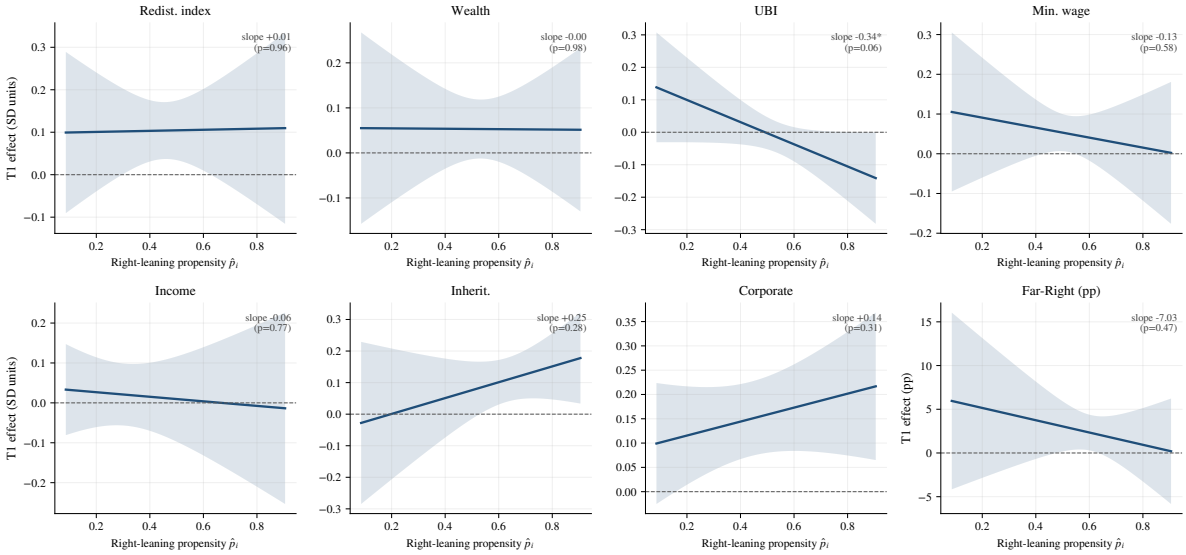


Figure 8. Backfire (I): the forced-exposure effect as a continuous function of right-leaning propensity. Predicted effect of T1 at each value of $\hat{p}_i$, with 95% confidence bands, from a linear interaction model that also includes the other treatment arms and controls. Outcomes in control-group SD units except the far-right platform (percentage points). The annotated slope is the coefficient on T1 × $\hat{p}_i$; a negative slope on a pro-redistribution outcome indicates that right-leaning respondents move *against* the article's message.

Backfire does not come with a lower reported belief. Table 9 estimates the updating weight λ from the knowledge questions. Readers of the left article move their median answer on inflation for low-income households from the control group's 7.9% to 10.0%, three-quarters of the way to the article's 10.7% ($\hat{\lambda} = 0.75$, with bootstrap intervals within [0.74, 0.82]), whether forced, voluntary or chosen; skippers and right-article readers, who never saw the figure, do not move

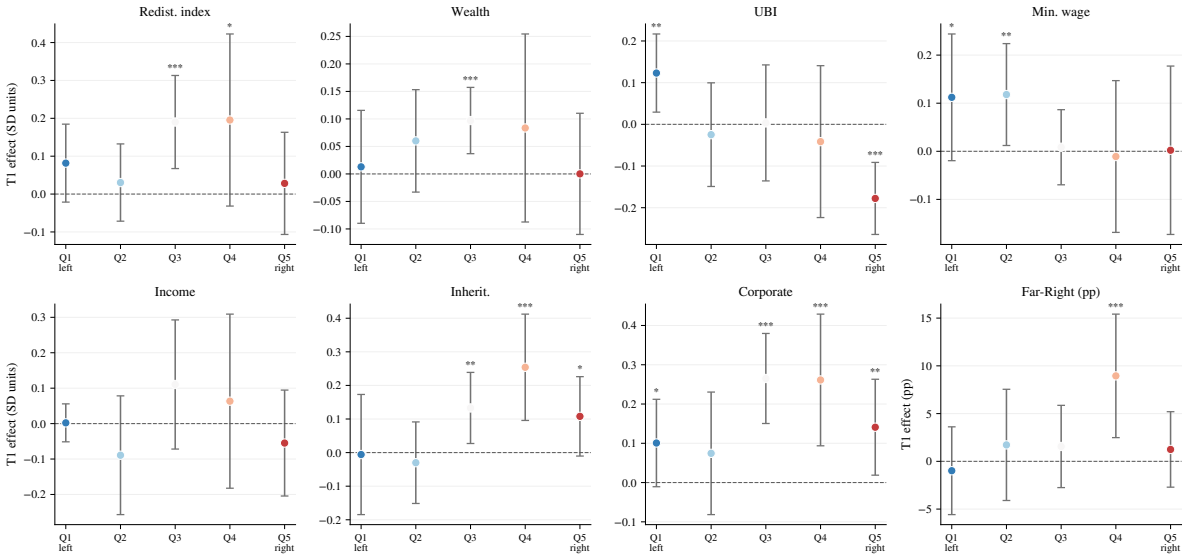


Figure 9. Backfire (II): the forced-exposure effect by quintile of right-leaning propensity. Coefficients on T1 $\times Q_k$ with 95% confidence intervals, Q1 = most left-leaning, Q5 = most right-leaning; stars mark $p < 0.10$. Same specification as Figure 8 with quintile indicators replacing the linear interaction.

($\hat{\lambda} = 0.00$ and 0.04). Within forced exposure $\hat{\lambda}$ is flat across right-leaning propensity, 0.74–0.82 from the most left- to the most right-leaning quintile. The respondents whose UBI preference moves against the article report its central figure as readily as anyone else. Section 8.3 discusses what these answers measure and what they imply for the mechanism.

6.7 Spillover to the Migration-Laden Bundle

Because the platforms bundle a fiscal with a migration position, the party effects above are also effects on migration-laden choices. Respondents who read the left article are less likely to rank first the Center-Right platform, selective skilled migration with moderate tax cuts: by 4.0 points when they chose the article and 3.0 points when they opened it voluntarily, in both the linear-probability and probit specifications (Table 7, Panel A). The coefficient on the broader restrictive-migration bundle ($\omega \cup \sigma$) has the same sign but is imprecise (−2.6 points, $p > 0.1$; Figure 10). An article that says nothing about migration is thus associated with a shift away from a platform defined jointly by fiscal and migration positions; because the two dimensions are aligned across platforms by design, we do not attribute the shift to migration attitudes specifically.

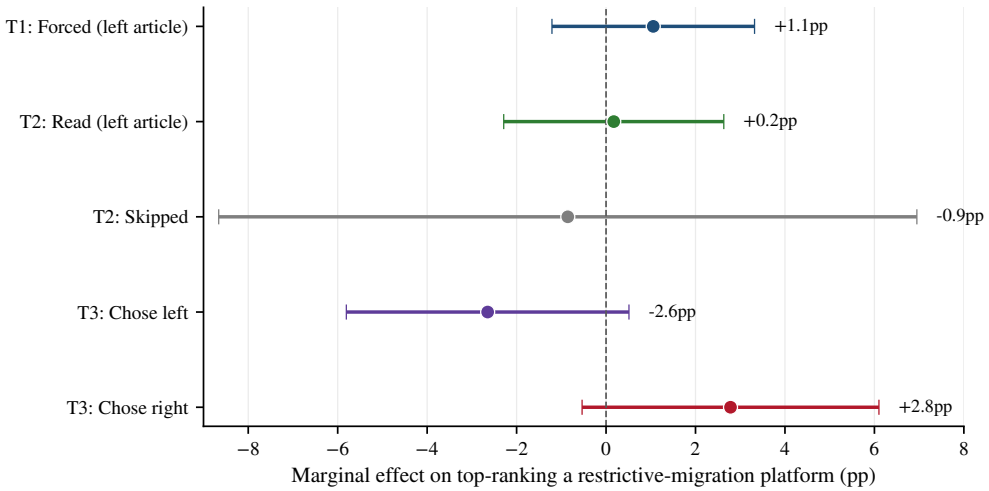


Figure 10. Economic narrative and the migration-laden bundle. Marginal effects (pp) on top-ranking a restrictive-migration platform (ω or σ), Table 5 column 5; 95% confidence intervals.

7 Robustness

We report robustness checks in two tables. Table 6 asks whether the results depend on how carefully respondents engaged with the survey; Table 7 asks whether they depend on how we estimate and how we compute standard errors. Table C.3 in Appendix C adds the placebo control, the order of the headlines, and reweighting.

Inattentive respondents. Restricting the sample to the 3,640 respondents who complied with the attention check on the first attempt leaves the point estimates unchanged (Table 6, Panel A): forced exposure 0.13 SD, voluntary reading 0.20 SD, choosing the left article 0.26 SD. The effect of choosing the right article keeps its size (−0.11 SD) but loses precision ($p = 0.11$) in the smaller sample. Policy by policy, the left-article effects on wealth, inheritance and corporate taxes and the right-article effects on UBI and the minimum wage are the same in both samples. Because respondents who never complied were screened out before completing the survey, this is a check on immediate versus prompted compliance rather than on attentive versus inattentive respondents, which makes the stability less surprising than it might appear.

Experimenter demand. Because both articles are politically coded, respondents may infer what the survey is looking for and answer accordingly. The closing question asks whether the survey felt politically slanted (Appendix B.9). Table 6, Panel B, shows that respondents do notice: relative to a control group in which 85.0% report no slant, reading the left article raises the share reporting a left-leaning survey by 4.1 to 4.9 percentage points, and choosing the right article lowers it by 2.6 points. The perception is real but small, and it does not drive the results. Among the 3,746 respondents who report no slant, the index coefficients are *larger* than in the full sample (T1 +0.14 against +0.10 SD; T2-read +0.24 against +0.19; T3-left +0.28 against

+0.27), and controlling for perceived slant leaves every coefficient within 0.01 SD of its baseline value. If demand effects were generating the estimates, both checks would move them toward zero; both move them away from it.

Binary outcomes. The platform outcomes are estimated by linear probability models in the main text. Probit average marginal effects (Table 7, Panel A) reproduce them: the coefficient on ranking the Center-Right platform first is −4.0 points for those who chose the left article and −3.0 points for voluntary readers under either estimator, and the coefficients on the restrictive-migration bundle are imprecise under both.

Few clusters. With 16 state clusters, conventional cluster-robust inference over-rejects. Table 7, Panel B, reports wild-cluster bootstrap-t p-values next to the cluster-robust ones for every arm and outcome. The results the paper leans on survive: voluntary reading and choosing the left article remain significant at 1% on the index and on the wealth, inheritance and corporate taxes, and choosing the right article remains significant on UBI ($p = 0.002$) and the minimum wage ($p = 0.018$). Two coefficients do not survive at conventional levels: forced exposure on the index ($p = 0.14$) and choosing the right article on the index ($p = 0.08$). We have accordingly presented those two as suggestive throughout. The ordering of the decomposed coefficients does not depend on them, but it is descriptive (Section 5.1).

Placebo control, article order, and reweighting. Table C.3 addresses three features of the design. First, the control group pools a pure control with a placebo that read an unrelated text; the placebo indicator is zero on the index (0.03 SD, $p = 0.56$) and on every policy, and using the pure control alone as the comparison group leaves the treatment effects unchanged. Second, the two headlines in the choice arm were shown in random order; the order shifts the share choosing the right article by 3 points ($p = 0.16$), and the coefficient for choosing the left article is positive and significant whichever headline came first (0.20 and 0.35 SD). Third, the sample is a quota sample: it meets its gender and education targets but under-represents respondents aged 18–24 by 6.6 and those aged 65 or over by 8.4 percentage points, and it over-represents AfD voters (17.6% of party voters against 10.4% in 2021). We therefore re-estimate with raking weights matching the SOEP (2022) margins for gender, age and education, and separately with weights that additionally set the AfD share to the 2021 result (10.4%) or to the February 2025 result (20.8%). The latter two are a sensitivity analysis with respect to the AfD share rather than a correction to a known electorate: the survey elicits the 2021 vote, so the first is appropriate if recall is accurate and the second if recall drifted toward contemporaneous preference during the campaign in which the survey was fielded; together they bracket the plausible range. Voluntary reading and choosing the left article are invariant across all schemes (0.18–0.19 and 0.26–0.28 SD), which also indicates that these effects do not vary appreciably with age, gender or education; weighting and controlling would otherwise diverge. Forced exposure ranges from

Table 6. Robustness: respondent attention and experimenter demand

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Panel A: Attention-check robustness						
	Redistribution index		T3 Left		T3 Right	
	Full sample	AC-passers	Full	AC-passers	Full	AC-passers
T1: Forced (left article)	0.103**	0.125***				
	(0.043)	(0.029)				
T2: Read (left article)	0.190***	0.202***				
	(0.026)	(0.029)				
T2: Skipped	-0.093	-0.060				
	(0.082)	(0.103)				
T3: Chose left	0.265***	0.258***				
	(0.039)	(0.051)				
T3: Chose right	-0.093**	-0.107				
	(0.041)	(0.066)				
Observations	4,524	3,640				
Wealth tax			0.235***	0.212***	-0.020	-0.027
			(0.038)	(0.057)	(0.038)	(0.058)
UBI			0.036	0.053	-0.198***	-0.190***
			(0.053)	(0.051)	(0.047)	(0.072)
Min. wage			0.117*	0.093*	-0.107***	-0.141***
			(0.062)	(0.049)	(0.034)	(0.044)
Income tax			0.058	0.049	-0.037	-0.047
			(0.066)	(0.046)	(0.030)	(0.031)
Inheritance tax			0.214***	0.220***	0.024	0.009
			(0.032)	(0.039)	(0.046)	(0.046)
Corporate tax			0.227***	0.236***	-0.073	-0.072
			(0.047)	(0.057)	(0.048)	(0.073)
Panel B: Experimenter demand — perceived slant of the survey						
	Perceived slant (pp)				Redistribution index	
	Leaned left	Leaned right	Unbiased		Unbiased only	Bias control
T1: Forced (left article)	4.14**	-0.25	-3.89*		0.141***	0.107**
	(1.66)	(1.20)	(2.27)		(0.044)	(0.045)
T2: Read (left article)	4.92**	-0.49	-4.42*		0.235***	0.195***
	(2.01)	(1.23)	(2.68)		(0.035)	(0.027)
T2: Skipped	3.14	-3.84**	0.70		-0.052	-0.094
	(2.64)	(1.65)	(3.19)		(0.089)	(0.080)
T3: Chose left	3.77**	0.57	-4.34*		0.281***	0.269***
	(1.59)	(1.37)	(2.37)		(0.034)	(0.039)
T3: Chose right	-2.62*	1.60	1.02		-0.100**	-0.094**
	(1.43)	(1.11)	(1.82)		(0.046)	(0.041)
Control-group mean	10.4	4.7	85.0			
Observations	4,524	4,524	4,524		3,746	4,524

Notes: Panel A re-estimates the main specifications on the 3,640 respondents who passed the attention check on the first attempt; columns (1)–(2) report the redistribution index by arm and columns (3)–(6) the effects of choosing each article on the six policies. Panel B uses the closing question asking whether respondents perceived the survey as politically slanted (Appendix B.9): columns (1)–(3) report treatment effects in percentage points on each response, and columns (5)–(6) re-estimate the index specification on the subsample who perceived no slant and on the full sample controlling for perceived slant. Estimates larger in column (5) than in the baseline indicate that experimenter demand attenuates rather than generates the results. Outcomes are standardized to the control group (mean 0, SD 1), so coefficients are effect sizes in control-group standard-deviation units. Standard errors clustered at the federal-state level ($G = 16$) in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$. All specifications include stratification and demographic controls (nationality, age, gender, education, household income, marital status, religion, place of birth, employment, housing tenure, income source, and 2021 vote). Omitted category: no-article control group.

Table 7. Robustness: functional form and inference with few clusters

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
Panel A: Binary outcomes — linear probability model versus probit (percentage points)							
	Restrictive-migration bundle		Center-Right (ω)				
	LPM	Probit AME	LPM	Probit AME			
T1: Forced (left article)	1.06	1.11	-1.39	-1.44			
	(1.16)	(1.19)	(1.35)	(1.33)			
T2: Read (left article)	0.17	0.20	-3.04**	-3.04**			
	(1.26)	(1.26)	(1.45)	(1.42)			
T2: Skipped	-0.86	-0.87	-2.76	-2.75			
	(3.98)	(3.90)	(4.18)	(4.30)			
T3: Chose left	-2.65	-2.59	-3.96**	-4.00**			
	(1.61)	(1.58)	(1.77)	(1.81)			
T3: Chose right	2.78	2.81	-0.98	-1.03			
	(1.69)	(1.74)	(1.90)	(1.88)			
Observations	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524			
Panel B: Inference with few clusters — wild-cluster bootstrap p-values (federal states, $G = 16$)							
	Index	Wealth	UBI	Min. wage	Income	Inherit.	Corporate
T1 Forced – cluster-robust p	0.016	0.135	0.396	0.073	0.956	0.029	0.000
wild-cluster bootstrap p	0.135	0.267	0.387	0.106	0.962	**0.064**	**0.006**
T2 Read – cluster-robust p	0.000	0.000	0.527	0.003	0.432	0.000	0.000
wild-cluster bootstrap p	**0.000**	**0.002**	0.532	**0.020**	0.459	**0.010**	**0.000**
T2 Skipped – cluster-robust p	0.257	0.449	0.090	0.048	0.507	0.184	0.999
wild-cluster bootstrap p	0.323	0.484	0.181	**0.099**	0.514	0.301	0.999
T3 Left – cluster-robust p	0.000	0.000	0.490	0.058	0.374	0.000	0.000
wild-cluster bootstrap p	**0.000**	**0.000**	0.500	**0.088**	0.462	**0.000**	**0.001**
T3 Right – cluster-robust p	0.023	0.595	0.000	0.001	0.205	0.606	0.125
wild-cluster bootstrap p	**0.083**	0.605	**0.002**	**0.018**	0.210	0.624	0.203

Notes: Panel A reports marginal effects in percentage points on top-ranking a restrictive-migration platform (ω or σ) and the Center-Right platform, from linear probability models and from probit average marginal effects (delta-method standard errors; the probit converged in all cases). Panel B compares the cluster-robust p-value with a wild-cluster bootstrap-t p-value (Cameron, Gelbach and Miller 2008; Webb six-point weights; null imposed; 4,999 replications; bold: $p < 0.10$), which is robust to the small number of clusters; outcomes are in control-group SD units. Standard errors clustered at the federal-state level ($G = 16$) in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$. All specifications include stratification and demographic controls (nationality, age, gender, education, household income, marital status, religion, place of birth, employment, housing tenure, income source, and 2021 vote). Omitted category: no-article control group.

0.09 to 0.15 SD. The one sensitivity is the coefficient for choosing the right article: −0.09 to −0.10 SD under the demographic and 2021 weights, but −0.04 SD and insignificant at the higher AfD share.

8 Mechanisms and Interpretation

8.1 Taking Stock of the Model

Table 8 sets the findings against three readings of the model of Section 2: accuracy only, in which there is no cost of exposure or of revision at any stage; dissonance only, in which both costs are large at every stage for respondents to whom the message is uncongenial; and the hybrid, in which the cost of exposure governs the choice, accuracy governs the factual belief, and resistance is confined to the step from fact to policy. Each row is a finding and each column asks whether a reading can produce it; Appendix E.6 derives every verdict from the model. Four findings do not depend on who selects into reading (Panel A). Three do (Panel B): they compare groups defined by their own choices, and the coefficient for such a group is the difference between where it started and where the population started, plus its movement. Given the sorting in row 1, any updating rule produces rows 5 and 7. Left-choosers can end 0.27 SD above the control group under pure Bayesian updating simply by starting higher, and at the intent-to-treat level, offering and imposing the article do not differ on the index or, after adjustment for multiple testing, on any policy (Table 1, Panel C). Row 6 says a little more: skippers support transfers less than the control group, as (B) and (C) predict and as (A) does only if right-leaning respondents care less about the topic or trust the article less (Appendix E.6). These contrasts describe what a fragmented environment delivers, which is why we report them, but they do little to tell the readings apart.

Accuracy alone fails at the choice stage (row 1). Without a cost of exposure, the value of information rises with the distance between message and prior (Appendix E.2), so a respondent who expects the two articles to be equally accurate reads the one that disagrees with her; respondents do the opposite. The verdict rests on that expectation: a respondent who expects the uncongenial article to be less accurate chooses the congenial one with no psychological cost at all (Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2006). If that expectation survived reading, it would also lower the updating weight of right-leaning readers (Appendix E.2), which their reported beliefs do not show. Dissonance alone fails at the belief stage (row 2). It predicts that respondents for whom the left article is uncongenial discount its facts, but the most right-leaning fifth of forced readers report the article's figure as readily as the most left-leaning fifth: both give a median answer of 10.0% ($\hat{\lambda} = 0.81$ versus 0.74, the difference reflecting their priors; Table 9). The verdict holds to the extent that the answers measure belief rather than recall (Section 8.3). With a mapping from fact to policy common to all respondents, neither single-force reading produces the narrow backfire: accuracy alone moves preferences all the way toward what the fact implies, and a cost

of revision slows that movement without reversing it. Both produce it if the most right-leaning respondents take a higher inflation burden on the poor to argue against a basic income. The hybrid is consistent with all four because it lets the forces act at different points. The cost of exposure governs the choice of what to read (Prediction P1); accuracy governs what readers report believing (Prediction P2, with $\hat{\lambda} \approx 0.75$ throughout); and resistance appears only at the step from the fact to a policy position, where the cost of revising a position keeps preferences from following beliefs and where, on UBI in the most right-leaning fifth, the movement reverses (Prediction P3). It places the resistance where rows 2 and 4 show it to be, so its fit to those rows describes rather than tests it; what the table isolates is which restrictions the data reject.

The reversal is the one finding the model does not attribute to a single cause. In the two-tier model of Section 2.5, it requires either an identity motive, a wish to hold a position away from the one the source advocates that outweighs the accuracy motive on that policy, or a mapping from fact to policy that, for these respondents, runs against the article. Both produce what the table shows, a fact reported in full and a policy that moves the other way. They differ in what the reversal responds to: the identity motive to who sends the message, the mapping to what the respondent believes the policy would do. Section 8.3 discusses the evidence on each, and Section 8.4 how the next wave separates them.

8.2 Why Policy Moves Left but Politics Moves Right

Forced exposure to the left article raises desired redistribution by 0.10 SD, and those who read it voluntarily or by choice end 0.2–0.3 SD above the control group, yet none of these groups ranks either left platform first significantly more often (Table 5; for those who chose the article, +2.3 and +1.8 points, neither robust). On party preference the left article does not move votes to the left: voluntary readers are 3.0 points less likely to rank the Center-Right platform first (bootstrap $p = 0.04$), those who chose the article 4.0 points (bootstrap $p = 0.07$), and forced exposure raises far-right support (below). Respondents who chose the right article are 3.8 points more likely to rank the far-right platform first (bootstrap $p = 0.005$) and 2.4 points less likely to rank the Center-Left first. Persuasion on economics does not convert into votes for the left, while the far-right platform gains under both articles.

Roemer (1998) explains why. When political competition has a second, non-economic dimension, parties offer bundles, and a voter persuaded on the economic dimension can move only to a platform whose position on the second dimension she accepts. Our platforms bundle fiscal with migration positions by design: the two left platforms (π, θ) pair redistribution with open or inclusive migration; the two right platforms (ω, σ) pair tax cuts with selective or restrictive migration (Table B.1). Appendix E.5 writes the argument as a two-dimensional spatial model. A narrative that shifts a respondent's fiscal ideal point changes the relative appeal of any two platforms in proportion to the difference in their fiscal positions, whatever her migration preference, but changes her first choice only if she was close to indifference; and

Table 8. Which reading of the model survives the evidence?

What the experiment shows	Estimate (control-group SD units unless noted)	Can this reading produce the finding? (A) Accuracy only $\varphi_i = \kappa_i = 0$	(B) Dissonance only, φ_i and κ_i large	(C) Hybrid φ_i chooses, α_i believes
Panel A: Findings that do not rest on self-selection				
Stage 1: what people choose to read (Prediction P1; the sign of $\varphi_i - \alpha_i\lambda_i$)				
(1) Choice is confirmatory: readers pick the article that agrees with them	Right-leaning choose the growth article 61–67%, left-leaning 48–52%; +5 pp per step of self-placement, $p < 0.001$ (Figure 4)	✗[a]	✓	✓
Stage 2: what people believe (Prediction P2; the weight λ_i on the fact)				
(2) Opponents report the article's figure as readily as supporters	$\hat{\lambda} = 0.75$ in every arm that saw the figure, 0.74–0.82 across $\hat{p}_i$ quintiles; the two arms that did not, 0.00 and 0.04 (Table 9)	✓	✗[c]	✓
Stage 3: what people then want (Predictions P2 and P3; the response of the policy)				
(3) Forced exposure moves preferences, but weakly and unevenly	Index $+0.103^{**}$, corporate tax $+0.165^{***}$, inheritance $+0.087^{**}$; wealth +0.051 and UBI −0.022 n.s. (Table 2, Table 3)	✓	✓	✓
(4) Backfire appears on one policy, for one group, and on no other policy	UBI: T1 × $\hat{p}_i = -0.341^{*}$; Q5 -0.178^{***} against Q1 $+0.123^{**}$. Index interaction +0.013 n.s.; far-right interaction n.s. (Table C.4)	✓[b]	✓[b]	✓
Panel B: Contrasts between self-selected groups (selection term, Appendix E.6)				
(5) For identical content: chosen > read > forced	Index: chose left $+0.265^{***}$ > read $+0.190^{***}$ > forced $+0.103^{**}$ (Table 2, col. 2)	*any updating rule, given the sorting of row 1*		
(6) Respondents who decline the article already differ from the control group	Index −0.093 n.s., but UBI -0.185^{*} and min. wage -0.176^{**} (Table 3)	*(B) and (C); (A) only if the right cares less about the topic or trusts the article less*		
(7) Which group of choosers departs further from the control group flips by policy	Gap of 0.358 SD on the index ($+0.265^{***}$ against -0.093^{**}); $\hat{\beta}_L + \hat{\beta}_R = +0.171^{***}$ on the index but -0.161^{*} on UBI (Table 2, Table 4)	*any updating rule, given the sorting of row 1*		
Panel A rows the reading cannot produce (✗)		**row 1, unless note a**	**row 2, unless note c**	**none**

Notes: Each row is a finding; each column asks whether a reading of the model in Section 2 can produce it (✓ consistent, ✗ inconsistent). (A) has no cost of exposure or revision; (B) makes both costs large at every stage; (C) lets the cost of exposure govern the choice and accuracy the factual belief, and confines resistance to the step from fact to policy, where the reversal comes from an identity motive ($\eta_i > \alpha_i$) or a mapping that runs against the article ($g_i' < 0$). Appendix E.6 derives every verdict. (C) places the resistance where rows 2 and 4 show it to be, so its fit to them describes rather than tests it: the informative content is *which* restrictions the data reject. Row 2 rests on the forced-exposure quintiles; row 3's size depends on the mapping g_i, which no reading fixes. Panel B compares groups defined by their own choices, so each coefficient adds a selection term to the movement (E.9).

[a] Given that respondents expect the two articles to be equally accurate (Section 2.3); a respondent who expects the uncongenial article to be less accurate chooses the congenial one even without a cost of exposure (Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2006). [b] Only if the most right-leaning respondents take a higher inflation burden on the poor to argue against a basic income ($g_i' < 0$); with a mapping common to all, neither (A) nor (B) produces movement against the article. [c] Only to the extent that the knowledge questions measure belief rather than recall of the article's figure (Section 8.3); a respondent who discounts the article can still report its number.

Estimates are OLS coefficients from (8) in control-group SD units, taken from the tables cited; row 6 is descriptive ($n = 149$, selected). Romano–Wolf p-values are in Table 3, Panel B, and wild-cluster bootstrap p-values in Table 7, Panel B: row 3's index effect survives cluster-robust but not bootstrap inference ($p = 0.135$) and is read as suggestive. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

with fiscal and migration positions aligned, a respondent with restrictive migration views is far from indifference between a right and a left platform. A respondent persuaded by the left article that inflation is regressive and that redistribution is warranted therefore faces, on the left, platforms that also require accepting a migration stance she may reject, and in the model only respondents already close to indifference cross. Among those who chose the left article, the Center-Right's loss is matched by the gains of the two left platforms, neither significant on its own; a leftward fiscal shift can move first choices out of the Center-Right in no other direction. A respondent persuaded by the right article faces no such tension: lower redistribution and restrictive migration sit in the same bundle, and that article also links the citizen's allowance to foreign recipients (Appendix A.2), so it may move migration preferences as well as fiscal ones. The bundling account thus explains why the left narrative does not convert into votes for the left: its audience is split on the second dimension. It does not explain why the far-right platform gains.

That gain does not fit the account. Forced exposure to the left article raises far-right support by 2.5 points (bootstrap $p = 0.01$), and voluntary readers of the left article rank the far-right platform first 3.2 points more often, close to the 3.8 points among those who chose the right article; the linear interaction does not tie the forced-exposure effect to right-leaning propensity, though by quintile it is concentrated in the fourth (Table C.4). A shift of the fiscal ideal point cannot move a respondent from any other platform to the far-right one: its fiscal position, a flat tax with lower spending and large corporate tax cuts, is the most conservative of the four, so a leftward shift lowers its appeal relative to every other platform (Appendix E.5). The effect requires the article to move something else: the salience of the citizen's allowance, for instance, which both articles mention (the left article's example of hardship is a recipient), or the appeal of the platform that respondents see as the vehicle of economic protest. We report it as unexplained by the bundling account; separating the channels requires platforms that vary the fiscal and the migration dimension independently, which ours do not.

8.3 Beliefs Move, Preferences Resist

Table 9 estimates the updating weight λ of (3) from the two knowledge questions, using the control group's median answer as the prior under random assignment. Readers of the left article move their median estimate of inflation for low-income households from 7.9% to 10.0%, three-quarters of the way to the article's 10.7% ($\hat{\lambda} = 0.75$ in each case, with bootstrap intervals inside [0.74, 0.82]), whether the article was imposed (T1), opened (T2) or chosen (T3). The two arms that never saw the figure do not move: skippers ($\hat{\lambda} = 0.00$) and right-article readers (0.04). On the overall 2022 rate, which both articles state, left-article readers move 90–100% of the way; right-article readers, whose article mentions the figure once before turning to growth, move 10%. The shortfall from $\hat{\lambda} = 1$ on the low-income figure reflects rounding: the modal answer is 10, the article says 10.7. For the arms defined by a choice, the control group's answer

is the right prior only if those who choose start where the population does; since the most right-leaning fifth start lower (below), the argument rests on the comparison within quintiles under forced exposure.

The result that matters is the profile across ideology. Within forced exposure, $\hat{\lambda}$ is 0.74, 0.75, 0.82, 0.74 and 0.81 from the most left-leaning to the most right-leaning quintile. Because answers heap at round numbers, the median answer after reading is 10.0% in four of the five quintiles, so these differences mostly reflect differences in the prior. A measure that does not rest on the median tells the same story: forced exposure raises the share of respondents whose answer lies within a point of the article's figure by 30 percentage points in the left-leaning half of $\hat{p}_i$ and by 34 in the right-leaning half (Table C.5, Panel D). The respondents whose UBI preference moves against the article report its central statistic as readily as anyone. This is evidence against the account of backfire in which the reader discounts the message as propaganda ($\rho > 1$ in Section 2.5): a reader who disbelieved or misread the article would be expected to report a lower number. What remains is resistance at the step from the fact to the policy. Part of it is the cost of revising a policy position, which lets beliefs move substantially and redistributive preferences much less, the pattern Kuziemko et al. (2015) document for information about inequality. A cost of revision cannot reverse a movement, however, and the model offers two ways to do so (Section 2.5).

The first is identity: a respondent who wants her position on a basic income to mark the group she belongs to may move away from a position advocated by a source from the other side while conceding its fact. A fact is cheap to concede; a policy position that marks group membership is not (Kahan, 2013). UBI is the natural locus. It is the policy closest to the citizen's allowance, which the right-leaning press attacks by name, as the right article does, and whose recipients include the left article's own example of hardship (Appendix A); and it is the policy on which the control group is most divided (Figure 2). Nor need the motive be strong: the article does not propose a basic income, and when the position a respondent attributes to the source lies beyond what the fact implies for her, a weak identity motive can reverse the movement (Appendix E.4). The second is a model of the economy in which transfers feed inflation, so that a higher inflation burden on the poor argues for fewer transfers rather than more. That argument also circulates in the right-leaning press, and the right article closes on it: while social support has its place, "excessive spending risks fueling inflation" (Appendix A.2). In explanations of the recent inflation surge collected from US households, government spending is the leading demand-side cause, and Republican-leaning respondents name it far more often than Democrat-leaning ones (Andre et al., 2026). Among government causes, Republicans are also more likely than Democrats to name redistributive spending, such as Social Security, as the most important (Binetti et al., 2024). Both readings fit the profile of $\hat{\lambda}$ and the shape of the UBI effect in Figure 9, including the movement toward UBI in the most left-leaning fifth, which identity reads as affinity with the source ($\eta_i < 0$) and the mapping as $g_i' > 0$ for these respondents. This wave cannot tell them apart.

The pattern across policies narrows both readings without separating them. Within the most right-leaning fifth, forced exposure raises support for the corporate tax (0.14 SD) and the inheritance tax (0.11 SD), leaves the wealth tax and the minimum wage where they were, and lowers support only for a basic income (Table C.4, Panel B). A wish to stand apart from the source as such would move these respondents away from the positions the article advocates, including a higher tax on corporate profits; they move toward it. If identity is at work, it attaches to a basic income as a position that marks the group, not to the article. The mapping reading attaches there by construction, since the argument that transfers feed inflation concerns transfers and not taxes on profits.

This evidence has three limits. The knowledge questions ask what the rate *was*; a respondent can report a figure she remembers from the article without endorsing it, so $\hat{\lambda}$ conflates learning with acceptance. The placebo arms show the answers respond to exposure, and the homogeneity across ideology shows that whatever is measured does not vary with the respondent's politics, but the distinction between recalled and believed cannot be closed with these questions. The answers are also unincentivized, so they are stated beliefs, which partisans shade toward congenial answers when accuracy is not paid (Bullock et al., 2015; Prior et al., 2015). The control group's answers differ by ideology in the direction that shading of this kind, or a motivated belief, predicts: the most right-leaning fifth put inflation for low-income singles at 7.0%, essentially equal to overall inflation (6.9%), whereas the other quintiles put it about a point higher (Table 9, Panel B). After reading the article, the same fifth report its figure as the others do, with a median answer of 10.0%. Shading of this kind would pull their answers after reading away from the article's figure, so it works against the homogeneity we find. Whatever their stated prior reflects, it is the anchor of (2) (Section 2.4), and the article moves it as far as anyone else's. Finally, $\hat{\lambda}$ is a group-level median statistic; it identifies how far an arm moves, not how far any respondent does.

8.4 What This Wave Cannot Identify

Five limits bound what this wave can claim, and each points to a change of design. First, κ_i and prior precision are observationally equivalent in updating data, and the choice data do not separate them, because aversion to information reflects φ_i rather than κ_i (Appendix E.2); incentivized priors with a confidence interval, elicited before treatment, would identify λ_i and κ_i for each respondent, and incentivized posteriors would separate a believed figure from a remembered or expressive one. Second, confirmatory choice signs $\varphi_i - \alpha_i\lambda_i$ without measuring φ_i, and it rests on equal expected accuracy; eliciting the willingness to pay to read, or to avoid, each article would price exposure in money, and a question on expected accuracy would test the assumption. Third, the moderator $\hat{p}_i$ is built partly from items elicited after treatment; excluding them strengthens the backfire estimate (Appendix D), but a moderator measured before treatment would settle the question. Fourth, identity and a mapping from fact to policy

Table 9. Belief updating: group-level estimates of the updating weight λ

	N	Prior	Posterior	Signal	$\hat{\lambda}$	95% CI
Panel A: By arm (prior = control-group median)						
Inflation for low-income singles (left article: 10.7%); prior = 7.9						
T1: Forced (left article)	1,150	7.9	10.0	10.7	+0.75	[+0.74, +0.79]
T2: Read (left article)	1,002	7.9	10.0	10.7	+0.75	[+0.74, +0.82]
T2: Skipped	149	7.9	7.9	10.7	+0.00	[-0.43, +0.04]
T3: Chose left	490	7.9	10.0	10.7	+0.75	[+0.74, +0.82]
T3: Chose right	643	7.9	8.0	10.7	+0.04	[+0.00, +0.21]
Overall 2022 inflation (both articles: 7.9%); prior = 6.9						
T1: Forced (left article)	1,150	6.9	7.9	7.9	+1.00	[+0.89, +1.00]
T2: Read (left article)	1,002	6.9	7.8	7.9	+0.90	[+0.89, +0.90]
T2: Skipped	149	6.9	6.9	7.9	+0.00	[-0.90, +0.00]
T3: Chose left	490	6.9	7.8	7.9	+0.90	[+0.89, +1.00]
T3: Chose right	643	6.9	7.0	7.9	+0.10	[+0.00, +0.50]
Panel B: T1 by quintile of right-leaning propensity (prior = control median within quintile)						
Inflation for low-income singles (left article: 10.7%)						
Q1 (most left-leaning)	234	8.0	10.0	10.7	+0.74	[+0.67, +0.89]
Q2	256	7.9	10.0	10.7	+0.75	[+0.64, +0.85]
Q3	220	7.9	10.2	10.7	+0.82	[+0.74, +0.86]
Q4	221	8.0	10.0	10.7	+0.74	[+0.74, +0.85]
Q5 (most right-leaning)	219	7.0	10.0	10.7	+0.81	[+0.74, +0.85]
Overall 2022 inflation (both articles: 7.9%)						
Q1 (most left-leaning)	234	7.0	7.9	7.9	+1.00	[+0.89, +1.00]
Q2	256	6.9	7.8	7.9	+0.90	[+0.89, +1.00]
Q3	220	7.0	7.9	7.9	+1.00	[+1.00, +1.00]
Q4	221	6.9	7.9	7.9	+1.00	[+0.89, +1.00]
Q5 (most right-leaning)	219	6.9	7.9	7.9	+1.00	[+0.89, +1.00]

Notes: Group-level updating weights $\hat{\lambda}$ = (posterior − prior)/(signal − prior), where the posterior is the median answer to the end-of-survey knowledge question in the arm, the prior is the median answer in the control group (the counterfactual prior under random assignment), and the signal is the statistic asserted by the article. Medians are used because a thin right tail of implausible answers dominates means. 95% confidence intervals from a cluster bootstrap over federal states (999 replications; 499 in Panel B). T2 Skipped and T3 Right serve as placebos: neither group saw the low-income figure. Right-leaning propensity is the post-LASSO score of Table D.1.

that runs against the article predict the same backfire; attributing the same article at random to a left- or a right-leaning outlet would move η_i and leave g_i unchanged, and asking what each policy would do to inflation and to low-income households would reveal the sign of g_i'. Fifth, the platforms bundle fiscal and migration positions, and the right article carries a migration cue; a menu that crosses the two dimensions, and a version of the article without the cue, would turn the bundling account of Section 8.2 into a test. We plan a second wave along these lines.

9 Conclusion

We asked whether the choice of what to read about the economy polarizes preferences for redistribution and the vote, and whether forcing the other side on people backfires. In order to answer both questions, we carried out a four-arm experiment on 4,524 German adults, using two real narratives about the 2022–23 inflation surge.

We found that choosing what to read is highly confirmatory, and it shapes where people end up. Right-leaning respondents pick the growth article and left-leaning respondents the redistribution article. Forced exposure to the left article moves preferences toward it; respondents who chose that article end more than twice as far from the control group, a contrast that combines what the article does with who chooses to read it. The movement is specific to what each article argues (the left narrative moves taxes on the rich, the right narrative basic income), and the two narratives are not symmetric. The left article has the larger effect on policy preferences and none on support for the left platforms; respondents who chose the right article also rank a far-right platform first more often. This is what platforms that bundle fiscal with migration positions imply: the right bundle aligns the two dimensions for its audience, while the left bundle asks a persuaded voter to accept a migration stance she may not hold.

We also found that backfire is real, but still narrow, and not what the literature often assumed. Forced exposure to the redistribution narrative pushes the most right-leaning fifth of respondents away from universal basic income and the most left-leaning fifth toward it, and moves no other policy against the message. The right-leaning respondents who move against the article believe its central fact as fully as everyone else. Nothing prevents them from learning that inflation hit the poor harder; what they reject is the policy conclusion, either because a basic income marks the other side or because they believe transfers feed inflation, two readings this wave cannot separate. Information campaigns that aim to move contested policy positions by supplying facts should expect the facts to land and the positions to stay.

Our project faces some limitations. First, the sample is a quota sample that over-represents AfD voters; however, results are unchanged under reweighting, except that the right article's aggregate effect weakens when the sample is weighted to the 2025 election. Second, the moderator used to test backfire is built from observables measured after treatment, balanced across arms but not elicited before it. And, finally, the belief estimates are group-level medians from unincentivized knowledge questions that do not separate recall from acceptance. To go further

with this research, a second wave should be considered: a pre-registered, elicits incentivized priors with confidence intervals before treatment, willingness to pay for congenial and uncongenial content, beliefs and preferences on several policies together with what respondents expect each policy to do, the same article under a randomly attributed source, and a platform menu that varies fiscal and migration positions independently. It will identify both dissonance costs at the individual level, test directly whether the cost of revision attaches to the fact or to the policy, and tell whether backfire responds to who sends a message or to what respondents believe a policy would do.

The broader point is about the architecture of information rather than its content. In a fragmented environment the first decision a citizen makes is which reality to enter, and that decision does much of the polarizing work. Because it is made before reading, nothing read can correct it; only forced exposure shows what avoidance hides. Correcting the facts inside each reality changes beliefs; it does not, on our evidence, change the positions that define the sides.

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Online Appendix

Biased Information, Biased Preferences

A Treatment Materials

Both articles were assembled from published German reporting on the 2022–23 inflation surge, with hyperlinks to the original sources retained in the text so that respondents could see the political alignment of the outlets each drew on. Both open with the same official statistic, overall inflation of 7.9% in 2022, and diverge thereafter. The estimated reading time of two minutes was displayed to respondents.

Exposure differed by arm. Respondents in T1 were shown the full text of the left article. Respondents in T2 were shown its headline and a one-sentence description and chose whether to open it. Respondents in T3 were shown the headline and description of both articles and chose one. The texts below are English translations; the survey was administered in German.

A.1 Left-Leaning Article (T1, T2, and T3)

Social gap in inflation at its highest level: Poorer people have an inflation rate almost three percentage points higher than the wealthy

Estimated reading time: 2 minutes

Germany's inflation crisis: Record high of 7.9% in 2022! According to the Federal Statistical Office, inflation in Germany was 7.9 percent overall in 2022. In September, October and November, inflation reached double-digits, the highest level in the country's post-war history. But it hits the poorest the hardest. Inflation hits poorer families much harder than everyone else. According to the Hans Böckler Foundation, the inflation rate for wealthy people in November 2022 was 7.8 percent on average. In contrast, the inflation rate for single people with low incomes was 10.7 percent, almost three percentage points higher. This means that the rising costs of everyday goods such as food and energy are putting a greater burden on poorer households. This makes it even more difficult for them to make ends meet.

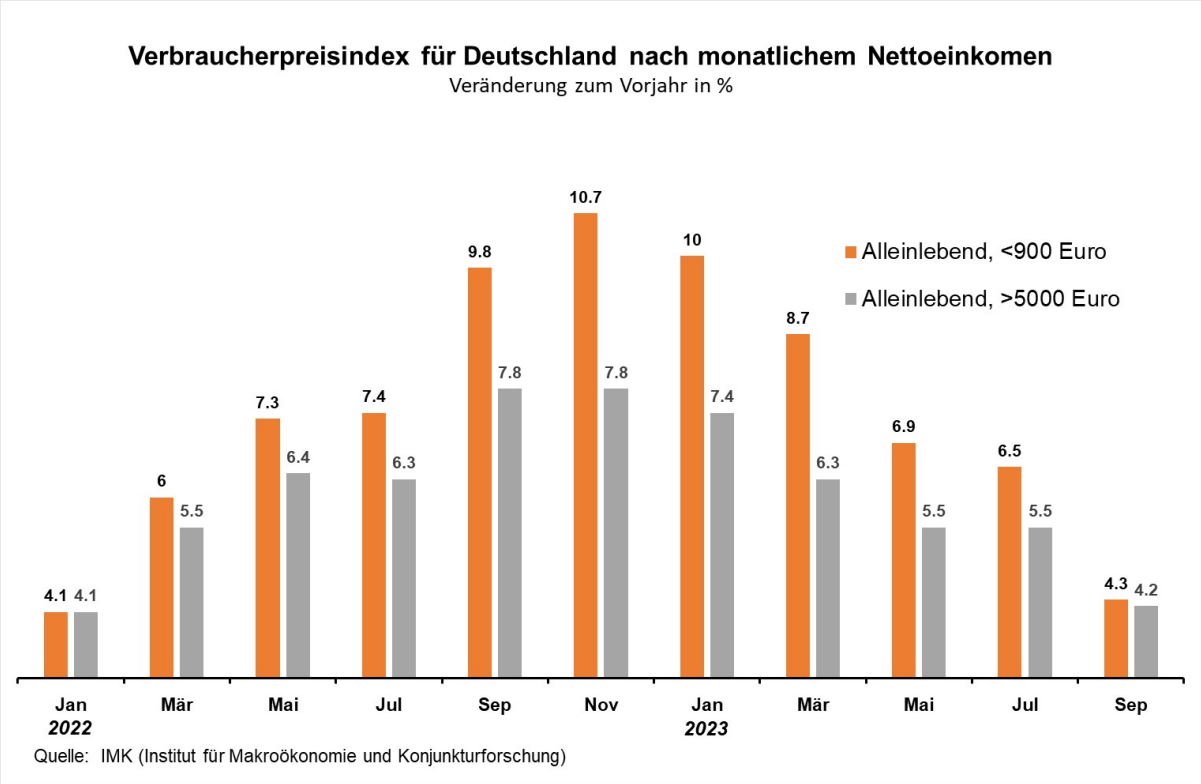


Figure A.1. Chart displayed in the left-leaning article.

Desperate decisions: families are starving while the number of personal bankruptcies is rising For Mrs. M., who wishes to remain anonymous, doing without is the reaction to the crisis: she receives a citizen's allowance, lives with her family near Bremen and all four have to get by on around 2,000 euros a month. Everything has to be paid for with that. And how can that be done when everything has become more expensive? Ms. M. has only one answer: starving. "I only eat twice a day to save money." But working people are also struggling. Stefanie Kaiser from the German Red Cross debt counseling service, Bremerhaven district association, reports: 'The number of employed people who come to us has increased by 50 percent in the last two years.' The vast majority of them have to file for bankruptcy. 'It's a catastrophe.' (Bremen Zwei).

The silent grip of inflation: prices remain high even when the storm has passed The time of galloping inflation seems to be over in 2024. But is everything OK again now? No. Now prices are stable, which slows inflation down. However, the price level remains high, even if the cost of individual products has fallen somewhat. Many people feel the inflation almost every day when they pay at the supermarket checkout. For the same money, you get significantly less goods (TAZ).

The inflation trap: How greed squeezes the poor Inflation hits low- to middle-income households particularly hard, as they struggle with rising prices for essential, almost irreplaceable goods. The minimum wage is 12.41 euros per hour and will rise to 12.82 euros in 2025. However, according to the German Trade Union Confederation (DGB), to compensate for inflation,

it would have to be 14 euros. The minimum wage commission has failed to ensure adequate inflation compensation—and the federal government allows it. The strategy of keeping wages low to fight inflation is only exacerbating the crisis, while the government is silent on the issue of "greedflation": excessive price increases by which companies use inflation as an excuse to boost their profits. Urgent action is needed to address these growing economic inequalities (TAZ).

What can be done? To combat the negative impact of inflation on poorer households, the German government must take decisive action, for example by capping electricity and gas prices. This is already providing them with some relief.

Increase corporate tax: The government should impose a tax on corporations that make extra profits during the energy crisis. Such excess profits should be taxed at a minimum of 50%, according to Oxfam, a global organization dedicated to fighting poverty, inequality, and injustice.

Promote a wealth tax: A re-introduction of the wealth tax on the rich or a one-off levy on large fortunes could be considered. Provide public services: This money should be used to improve education, healthcare, and social services to ensure that everyone can afford the basic necessities and to reduce the gap between rich and poor.

Raise the minimum wage: With real commitment, the government can help families struggling with rising costs, including by raising the minimum wage (Süddeutsche Zeitung). Remember, we are all in this stormy economic sea together. Let's make sure everyone has a sturdy ship.

A.2 Right-Leaning Article (T3 only)

Handouts won't save Germany: Why economic growth, not ever-increasing social benefits, is the real path to recovery

Estimated reading time: 2 minutes

According to the Federal Statistical Office, inflation in Germany was 7.9 percent overall in 2022. In September, October, and November, inflation reached double digits, the highest level in the country's post-war history.

The answer, however, is growth, not social benefits Rising prices in Germany are putting a strain on families and businesses. While immediate help is essential, experts are urging the government to focus on something even more important: economic growth. According to the European Commission, Germany's economic recovery has been sluggish, and the country's real GDP fell 0.3% in 2023, making it the only major economy in the developed world to contract in that year. The outlook for 2024 is not much better: according to DW, a 0.2% decline in GDP is forecast instead of the growth previously expected.

Instead of relying on inflation aid, Germany could focus on boosting its industry, attracting more investment and creating jobs. By prioritizing growth, the country can strengthen its

resilience and ensure lasting stability, rather than merely alleviating the symptoms of the problem with temporary aid.

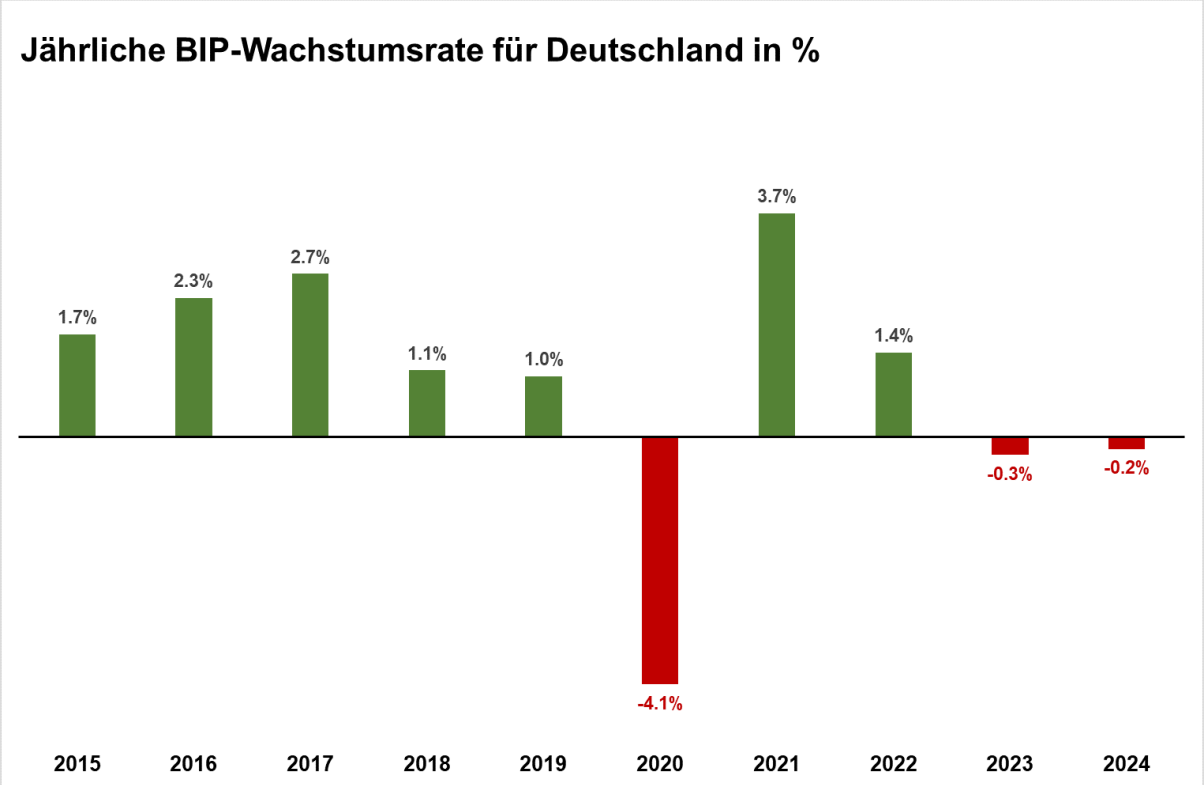


Figure A.2. Chart displayed in the right-leaning article.

We need more growth in Germany, not a "four-day week" Germany is at a critical point. It is facing an economic bottleneck, and boosting growth is more urgent than ever. As Christian Sewing, CEO of Deutsche Bank, emphasized at the WELT Economic Summit, focusing on growth and hard work, not a four-day week, is key to securing a stable economy for the future (Welt). However, the government's current emphasis on social benefits, such as the Citizen's Allowance, has raised concerns. The money, which is intended to support those in need, is likely to reduce the incentive to work (Welt). Many recipients prefer social benefits over employment. Especially since 40 percent of recipients are foreigners who do not have sufficient German language skills and therefore find it difficult to integrate into the labor market (FOCUS online). The CDU is bucking this trend. Its party leadership is calling for stricter penalties for those who turn down reasonable job offers. CDU leader Friedrich Merz noted that many of the 1.7 million employable recipients simply assume that it is more profitable to use citizen's allowance than to enter the workforce (Welt). The draft budget for 2025 reflects this: the proposed measures include the creation of stronger work incentives and stricter rules, which are expected to lead to budget savings of up to 5 billion euros in citizen's allowance. These savings would enable higher spending on pensions, investments in rail and road transport, child benefits and the military (Institute for Macrofinance).

Tax cuts to keep German jobs at home In September 2023, the German government announced

a new corporate tax cut of €7 billion per year—finally a step towards reviving the economy. After years of watching jobs and companies move to other countries, this relief gives small and medium-sized enterprises—the heart of local communities—the chance to thrive, invest, and create jobs here at home (DW). Joachim Nagel, President of the Deutsche Bundesbank, has expressed this clearly: 'In order to create an employment and investment-friendly environment, it is important to keep an eye on the tax burden on labor and capital.' Otherwise, Germany risks falling behind while global competitors with more business-friendly policies pull ahead (Financial Times). This tax break, totaling 32 billion euro over four years, is more than just a cut. It's about protecting Germany's economic strength and ensuring future generations are not left behind. When businesses thrive here, families feel the impact. Every job saved in Germany means stability for a family, better opportunities for young people and a stronger foundation for the country's future. By cutting taxes, Germany is finally giving its own citizens and businesses a real chance to succeed at home (Financial Times).

Reclaiming Germany's future: Fighting inflation with growth, not handouts To secure a future of prosperity, Germany must commit to policies that encourage economic growth, reduce government paternalism and reward hard work. While social support has its place, excessive spending risks fueling inflation and undermining productivity. With the right balance of incentives, tax relief and a focus on creating opportunities, Germany can enable its people to live independently and attract investment to sustain a strong economy.

Let us make growth, jobs and productivity a priority so that Germany becomes a country where prosperity is accessible to all—now and for generations to come.

A.3 Placebo Text (Control Group)

Half of the control group read the text below; the other half read nothing. The text is of comparable length to the treatment articles but unrelated to inflation, redistribution or politics. Table C.3 shows that outcomes do not differ between the two control subgroups, which is why they are pooled throughout.

> **The sweet journey of chocolate in Germany**
>
> Chocolate is a favourite treat all over the world, and Germany has played a significant part in its history and production. But have you ever wondered how this delicious delicacy is made? Let us take a journey through the chocolate-making process, paying particular attention to Germany's contribution to this sweet industry.
>
> It all begins with the humble cocoa bean, which grows in tropical regions far from Germany, such as West Africa and South America. The beans are harvested, fermented and dried before finding their way to chocolate factories in countries such as Germany, where the magic happens.
>
> In Germany the beans are carefully roasted to bring out their rich aroma. After roasting they are cracked open to release the cocoa nibs inside, which are then ground into a thick

brown paste known as cocoa mass. This is the basis of every chocolate product.

Germany is home to some of the world's finest chocolate manufacturers, known for their precision and quality. They blend the cocoa mass with sugar, milk and sometimes other ingredients, depending on whether they are making dark, milk or white chocolate. The mixture is then refined and conched—a process that smooths the texture and improves the flavour.

Finally the chocolate is tempered, a technique that gives it its glossy surface and the satisfying snap when a piece is broken. It is then moulded into bars, truffles or other delicious shapes, ready to be enjoyed.

German chocolate brands such as Ritter Sport and Milka are known worldwide for their high-quality products, each with its own distinctive taste and history. The next time you enjoy a piece of German chocolate, you will taste the careful craftsmanship that goes into every bite.

B Survey Instrument

The questionnaire was administered in German; the text below is an English translation. Blocks are listed in the order in which respondents saw them: consent, stratification, treatment (Appendix A), outcomes, covariates, and the closing knowledge and demand-effect questions.

B.1 Consent

Respondents were shown the following before entering the survey and could proceed only by selecting "Yes".

This questionnaire is part of a study on the economy in Germany. Before you decide to answer the questionnaire, it is important that you understand why this study is being conducted and what your role is in it.

1. This survey aims to analyse the views of the German population on various economic issues. It is important that you answer honestly.
2. You will be asked to answer questions in a short online survey. There are no right or wrong answers. If you do not know the answer, simply give your best guess. The questionnaire takes about 10 minutes to complete.
3. There are no foreseeable risks associated with participating. Participation is completely voluntary, and you can withdraw at any time without any disadvantages.
4. You will be rewarded for your participation.
5. All responses will be treated strictly confidentially. No information that could be used to identify you will be published. Only the researchers involved in this study will have access to the information you provide. The data will not be passed on to third

parties and will not be used for any purpose other than the study described above. In accordance with European regulations on the protection of personal data, you have the right to access, rectify, and delete the information you have provided.

By participating, you consent to your data being stored and processed for the stated purposes. Would you like to continue? Yes / No

B.2 Stratification Block

Asked before treatment: year of birth, gender, and highest completed education. These three variables define the quota targets and the randomization blocks.

Q2 How old are you?

- 18–24
- 25–34
- 35–44
- 45–54
- 55–64
- 65–74
- 75–84
- 85 or older

Q3 What is your gender?

- Male
- Female
- Non-binary / other
- Prefer not to say

Q86 What school, university or vocational qualification do you have? Please think of your highest qualification.

- Secondary education (intermediate school certificate / Realschulabschluss, general higher education entrance qualification / Abitur, Hauptschulabschluss, university of applied sciences entrance qualification, Fachoberschule certificate)
- Vocational qualification (in-company or school-based vocational training, training at a technical school, Technikerschule, vocational or technical academy)
- Bachelor's degree or higher (Bachelor's, university of applied sciences degree, Diplom or Master's degree, completed teacher training, doctorate / habilitation)

B.3 Redistributive-Policy Outcomes

Three items use a 0 to 10 agreement scale, one asks for a tax rate in percent, and two use a slider running from "reduce" to "increase" around the status quo, recorded on a 0 to 10 scale with 5 denoting no change.

Wealth tax (0–10). Please answer the following question on a scale of 0 to 10. To what extent do you agree or disagree with the introduction of a wealth tax in Germany that requires high net worth individuals to pay a percentage of their total wealth as tax? *0 = completely disagree, 10 = completely agree.*

Unconditional basic income (0–10). In the following, we would like to ask you about your views on an unconditional basic income. The state provides all citizens with a monthly income that covers the basic costs of living. This income is intended to replace existing social benefits and is financed by tax revenues. Everyone receives the same amount, regardless of whether they are employed or not. *0 = completely disagree, 10 = completely agree.*

Minimum wage (0–10). To what extent do you support the idea of increasing the minimum wage in Germany? *0 = completely disagree, 10 = completely agree.*

Top income-tax rate (0 to 100%). In Germany, the average tax burden of a single person earning the minimum wage is about 27% of total gross income (including social security contributions). In your opinion, what percentage of the total income should a single person earning over 280,000 euros gross per year pay in taxes (including social security contributions)? *Slider from 0 to 100%.*

Inheritance tax (0–10). If a person over the age of 27 in Germany inherits or receives €1 million in cash from their parents, they have to pay around 9% of the sum as inheritance tax. In your opinion, should the inheritance tax decrease, stay the same, or increase? Move the slider to the left to lower the rate or to the right to increase it; if you think the rate should stay the same, leave the slider in the middle. *Recorded 0 = reduce, 5 = keep, 10 = increase.*

Corporate profit tax (0 to 10). The current corporate profit tax in Germany is about 30%. In your opinion, should the corporate profit tax decrease, stay the same, or increase? Slider as above. *Recorded 0 = reduce, 5 = keep, 10 = increase.*

All six are standardized to the control group before estimation (Section 5.2); Figure 2 shows their untransformed distributions.

B.4 Political Platforms

Respondents ranked four fictitious platforms from 1 (most preferred) to 4, with the order of presentation randomized and a blank-vote option available. Each platform pairs a fiscal with a

migration position.

Table B.1. The four political platforms ranked by respondents

Platform	Migration position	Fiscal position
Left (π)	Open borders with equal rights and access to social services for all migrants; no detention or deportation	Radical redistribution of wealth; high taxes on the wealthy and corporations to fund comprehensive public services; no taxes on low incomes
Center-Left (θ)	Inclusive immigration policy with accessible legal pathways, integration programs and a simplified path to citizenship	Progressive tax system; tax the wealthy and corporations to provide public services and relief to middle- and low-income households
Center-Right (ω)	Selective legal immigration focused on skilled workers; strict measures against illegal immigration; emphasis on cultural integration	Moderate tax cuts for middle incomes and small businesses; simplified tax code; reduction of certain social programs
Far-Right (σ)	Strict immigration controls; limited merit-based system for highly skilled workers; strong border security	Single (flat) tax to reduce government spending; significant corporate tax cuts to stimulate the private sector

Notes: Outcome variables are indicators for ranking each platform first; the restrictive-migration bundle is the union of ω and σ. Fiscal and migration positions are aligned across platforms, which is why Section 6.7 does not attribute the estimated effects to migration attitudes specifically.

B.5 Cognitive Dissonance

Three items, each on a 1–7 scale. The second and third are reverse-scaled relative to the first; they are used as recorded.

Discomfort. How much discomfort or inner tension do you feel when you encounter a political view that differs from your own? *1 = no discomfort at all, 7 = very severe discomfort.*

Belief revision. To what extent do you agree with the following statement? "Disagreement makes me question my current beliefs." *1 = totally agree, 7 = totally disagree.*

Reconciliation. To what extent do you agree with the following statement? "I find it difficult to reconcile opposing arguments with my own beliefs." *1 = totally agree, 7 = totally disagree.*

B.6 Distributive Justice: The Flute Question

You are asked to give a flute as a gift to one of three children. Child A is exceptionally talented at playing the flute and has shown remarkable dedication and effort in developing musical skills. Child B comes from a socially deprived background and has no access to toys or leisure activities. Child C inherited the flute from a family member who was a talented flautist; the flute has emotional value and symbolises a family tradition.

1. Give the flute to Child A because of its exceptional musical talent and achievements. *(talent)*
2. Give the flute to Child B to fulfil its need for entertainment and leisure. *(need)*
3. Give the flute to Child C as an inheritance, honouring family tradition. *(inheritance)*
4. I don't know.

The question follows Sen (2009). Responses are balanced across arms (Table C.1).

B.7 Political Self-Placement

On a scale from 0 (far left) to 10 (far right), where would you place yourself politically? Asked at the end of the outcome block rather than before treatment, to avoid priming; it is therefore post-treatment and used only descriptively and in Appendix D.

B.8 Media Consumption

Media consumption is elicited in three stages. Respondents first name the category that is their primary news source. They are then asked whether they additionally use each of the other two categories, and are shown the outlet list for a category only if it is their primary source or they report also using it. Outlet questions allow multiple responses. Excluding the open *Other* option in each list, the three lists contain 46 named outlets; these are the media covariates entering the propensity model in Appendix D.

Primary source. What is your main source of information for news and current events? *TV, radio and print / Online news / Social media, messaging and video networks / None.*

Additional use. Do you also generally use [each remaining category] as a news source? *Yes / No.*

Social media, messaging and video networks (9 named outlets).

- Facebook
- YouTube
- WhatsApp
- X (formerly Twitter)
- Instagram
- TikTok
- Snapchat
- LinkedIn
- Telegram
- Other

TV, radio and print (19 named outlets).

- ARD (Tagesschau, Tagesthemen)
- ZDF (heute, heute-journal)
- RTL News
- Regional television
- Regional and local newspapers
- Regional radio

- n-tv
- Sat.1 Nachrichten
- Welt
- Bild / Bild am Sonntag
- Der Spiegel
- Focus
- ProSieben :newstime
- Die Zeit
- Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung
- Handelsblatt
- Süddeutsche Zeitung
- Tagesspiegel
- taz
- Other

Online news (18 named outlets).

- ARD News online
- t-online
- Bild.de
- n-tv.de
- Focus online
- Regional online newspapers
- Spiegel Online
- GMX
- ZDF News online
- Regional online television
- Zeit Online
- Yahoo! News
- FAZ.NET
- MSN News
- Google News, Apple News
- BBC, CNN, Reuters
- Financial Times
- DW
- Other

B.9 Closing Questions

Two knowledge questions close the survey. They elicit precisely the two statistics on which the left article rests, the overall 2022 inflation rate, stated in both articles, and the rate for low-income single households, stated only in the left article, and provide the post-treatment beliefs used to estimate the updating weight λ in Section 8.3. A final question asks whether respondents perceived the survey as politically slanted, and is used to test for experimenter-demand effects in Table 6, Panel B.

Q41 Knowledge. Please answer the following questions. *Note: at most one decimal place may be entered. Please enter a value in percent.*

1. How high was the annual inflation rate in Germany in 2022? *(True value 7.9%; stated in both articles.)*
2. How high was the inflation rate specifically for single people with low incomes in Germany in 2022? *(Value asserted by the left article: 10.7%; not mentioned in the right article.)*

Q47 Perceived slant. Do you think this survey was biased?

- Yes, I had the impression that the survey leaned politically to the left.
- Yes, I had the impression that the survey leaned politically to the right.
- No, it did not feel biased.

In the control group, 85.0% report that the survey felt unbiased, 10.4% that it leaned left and 4.7% that it leaned right.

C Additional Results

Reading and choice rates by arm are reported in Table C.2: willingness to open the article is high (87%) and roughly constant across political groups, ranging from 78% among non-voters to 93% among Linke voters, whereas the direction of choice in the choice arm is strongly sorted, from 48% choosing the right article among Greens voters to 67% among CDU/CSU voters. Whether to read is not an ideological decision; what to read is.

Table C.3 reports the placebo, order and reweighting checks discussed in Section 7.

Table C.5 distinguishes exposure to the left article from uptake of its content. Uptake is measured from the closing knowledge questions: a respondent has absorbed the article if her answer lies within one or two percentage points of the figure it asserts. Assignment to forced exposure raises uptake of the low-income figure from 11% to 43%, so about a third of forced readers demonstrably absorb it, a rate that is stable across definitions. Instrumenting uptake with assignment rescales the intent-to-treat effects to a per-absorber basis, roughly three times larger (0.33 SD on the index, 0.51 on the corporate tax); because the article also carries an anecdote and explicit recommendations, the exclusion restriction is strong and the per-absorber estimates should be read as an upper bound. Two features are informative beyond the rescaling. Adding assignment to T2 and T3 as instruments, the over-identification test rejects for the wealth tax ($p = 0.01$–0.02) but not for the index or the corporate and inheritance taxes: choosing the article moves the wealth tax through a channel beyond absorbing its facts. And right-leaning respondents absorb the low-income figure at a higher rate than left-leaning ones (48% against 40% in T1) while responding to it less on the index and negatively on UBI (-0.26 SD per absorber, $p < 0.10$), which restates the dissociation of Section 8.3 in per-absorber units.

Table C.1. Means and balancing tests across randomized groups

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)
	Mean of variable by group					p-value, equality of means			Signif. under
	T1	T2	T3	Control	Germany	T1 vs C	T2 vs C	T3 vs C	multiple testing
Stratification variables									
Male	0.49	0.50	0.48	0.50	0.51	0.63	0.99	0.41	No
18–24	0.10	0.10	0.11	0.11	0.17	0.80	0.66	0.77	No
25–34	0.17	0.17	0.15	0.15	0.14	0.19	0.24	0.93	No
35–44	0.18	0.16	0.15	0.19	0.15	0.79	0.09	0.03	No
45–54	0.22	0.20	0.23	0.20	0.14	0.23	0.85	0.10	No
55–64	0.22	0.22	0.23	0.23	0.18	0.38	0.30	0.79	No
65+	0.10	0.15	0.13	0.12	0.21	0.18	0.04	0.72	No
Bachelor+	0.28	0.28	0.25	0.28	0.26	0.97	0.82	0.10	No
Vocational	0.57	0.57	0.58	0.57	0.54	0.99	0.92	0.48	No
Secondary and below	0.15	0.15	0.17	0.15	0.20	0.98	0.67	0.30	No
Socio-economic characteristics									
No religion	0.45	0.46	0.46	0.45	0.38	0.83	0.72	0.70	No
Catholic	0.23	0.22	0.21	0.25	0.26	0.37	0.16	0.05	No
Protestant	0.16	0.17	0.16	0.15	0.33	0.52	0.15	0.41	No
Other religion	0.13	0.13	0.14	0.13	0.03	0.93	0.67	0.39	No
Not saying	0.03	0.02	0.02	0.02	0.003	0.64	0.83	0.79	No
Married	0.45	0.45	0.47	0.47	0.44	0.32	0.47	0.88	No
Full time	0.54	0.52	0.55	0.53	0.37	0.84	0.58	0.41	No
Part time	0.14	0.13	0.14	0.15	0.23	0.84	0.41	0.46	No
Self-employed	0.06	0.06	0.04	0.05	0.05	0.48	0.59	0.18	No
Not employed	0.26	0.29	0.27	0.27	0.35	0.66	0.33	0.78	No
HH income < €1,750	0.18	0.19	0.21	0.20	0.26	0.20	0.79	0.52	No
€1,751–3,000	0.32	0.30	0.30	0.29	0.25	0.19	0.49	0.78	No
€3,001–6,000	0.41	0.42	0.40	0.40	0.40	0.79	0.33	0.81	No
> €6,000	0.10	0.08	0.10	0.11	0.09	0.46	0.02	0.38	No
Prior voting behavior, 2021 (%)									
SPD	23.42	24.33	24.13	23.54	25.7	0.92	0.73	0.91	No
CDU/CSU	25.16	23.41	22.03	23.77	24.1	0.51	0.82	0.30	No
AfD	15.07	16.66	16.36	16.56	10.4	0.37	0.98	0.80	No
Greens	12.22	14.22	12.91	11.82	14.7	0.81	0.13	0.56	No
FDP	9.07	7.47	11.65	9.47	11.4	0.75	0.11	0.16	No
The Left	6.10	5.52	5.66	6.67	4.9	0.61	0.29	0.33	No
Other parties	8.97	8.18	7.95	8.18	8.8	0.55	0.89	0.40	No
Did not vote / blank	14.98	15.10	16.04	14.76	23.3	0.88	0.82	0.40	No
Notion of justice (flute question)									
Talent (utilitarian)	0.28	0.28	0.31	0.28		0.76	0.99	0.10	No
Need (egalitarian)	0.43	0.45	0.42	0.42		0.76	0.13	0.92	No
Inheritance (libertarian)	0.23	0.20	0.20	0.23		0.91	0.15	0.06	No
Don't know	0.07	0.06	0.07	0.07		0.89	0.55	0.87	No

Notes: Columns (1)–(4) report means by randomized group; column (5) the population benchmark (SOEP 2022 for demographics; official 2021 federal election result for voting). Columns (6)–(8) report p-values for the test of equality of means against the control group with heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors; column (9) indicates whether any difference remains significant after correcting for multiple hypothesis testing (Romano and Wolf, 2005).

Table C.2. Reading and choice rates by arm and by 2021 vote

	T2 (optional)		T3 (choice)	
	N	% who read	*N*	% choosing right
All respondents	1,151	87.1	1,133	56.8
By 2021 federal-election vote				
Linke	54	92.6	54	51.9
Greens	139	86.3	123	48.0
SPD	238	89.9	230	49.1
FDP	73	90.4	111	61.3
CDU/CSU	229	90.0	209	66.5
AfD	162	89.5	156	64.7
Others	82	80.5	69	53.6
Non-voter	174	77.6	181	54.1
By order in which the headlines were shown (choice arm only)				
Left headline shown first	–	–	601	55.4
Right headline shown first	–	–	532	58.3

Notes: Share of respondents in the optional arm who opened the left article, and share of respondents in the choice arm who opened the right (growth) article rather than the left one. Willingness to read is high and roughly constant across political groups; the direction of choice is strongly sorted. Party groups exclude respondents who did not report a 2021 vote choice.

Table C.3. Additional robustness: placebo control, article order, and reweighting

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
Panel A: Placebo text vs. pure control (coefficient on the placebo indicator, pure control omitted)							
	Index	Wealth	UBI	Min. wage	Income	Inherit.	Corporate
Placebo (history of chocolate)	0.034	-0.006	0.067	0.025	0.040	0.045	-0.018
	(0.058)	(0.085)	(0.052)	(0.036)	(0.057)	(0.055)	(0.057)
Panel B: Redistribution index under alternative samples and weights							
	Baseline	Pure control only	T3: left shown first	T3: right shown first	SOEP weights	AfD share = 10.4%	AfD share = 20.8%
T1: Forced (left article)	0.103**	0.119***	0.104**	0.102**	0.127**	0.113**	0.147**
	(0.043)	(0.045)	(0.043)	(0.042)	(0.050)	(0.044)	(0.061)
T2: Read (left article)	0.190***	0.206***	0.192***	0.192***	0.182***	0.186***	0.192***
	(0.026)	(0.036)	(0.026)	(0.025)	(0.031)	(0.032)	(0.029)
T2: Skipped	-0.093	-0.078	-0.096	-0.086	-0.070	-0.086	-0.084
	(0.082)	(0.096)	(0.080)	(0.081)	(0.074)	(0.083)	(0.093)
T3: Chose left	0.265***	0.279***	0.196***	0.349***	0.269***	0.278***	0.274***
	(0.039)	(0.065)	(0.059)	(0.056)	(0.044)	(0.043)	(0.051)
T3: Chose right	-0.093**	-0.077	-0.129*	-0.050	-0.091**	-0.106**	-0.046
	(0.041)	(0.057)	(0.072)	(0.038)	(0.041)	(0.047)	(0.052)
Observations	4,524	3,960	3,992	3,923	4,514	4,514	4,514
Effective sample size	–	–	–	–	3,930	3,720	3,654

Notes: Panel A adds an indicator for the placebo control group (which read a short text on the history of chocolate) to the decomposed specification, with the pure control group as the omitted category; a zero coefficient justifies pooling the two control groups. Panel B re-estimates the decomposed specification for the redistribution index: (2) excluding the placebo group so that the pure control is the only comparison group; (3)–(4) restricting the choice arm to respondents who saw the left (right) headline first, with all non-T3 respondents retained; (5)–(7) with raking weights that match the sample to population margins for gender, age group and education (SOEP 2022), and additionally to the 2021 or 2025 federal election result and turnout (respondents reporting a non-binary gender are dropped from the weighted specifications). Maximum weight 2.9. Standard errors clustered at the federal-state level ($G = 16$) in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$. All specifications include stratification and demographic controls (nationality, age, gender, education, household income, marital status, religion, place of birth, employment, housing tenure, income source, and 2021 vote). Omitted category: no-article control group.

Table C.4. Backfire: heterogeneity of the forced-exposure effect by right-leaning propensity (appendix)

	Redist. index (1)	Wealth (2)	UBI (3)	Min. wage (4)	Income (5)	Inherit. (6)	Corporate (7)	Far-Right (pp) (8)
Panel A: Continuous interaction with right-leaning propensity $\hat{p}_i$								
T1: Forced	0.105**	0.053	-0.025	0.045*	0.006	0.092**	0.168***	2.583**
	(0.043)	(0.034)	(0.025)	(0.026)	(0.064)	(0.038)	(0.043)	(1.115)
$\hat{p}_i$ (centered)	0.332**	0.293*	-0.261	-0.466***	0.352***	0.583***	0.323**	22.721***
	(0.163)	(0.177)	(0.251)	(0.156)	(0.123)	(0.109)	(0.145)	(6.290)
T1 × $\hat{p}_i$	0.013	-0.004	-0.341*	-0.126	-0.057	0.251	0.144	-7.028
	(0.245)	(0.231)	(0.184)	(0.229)	(0.194)	(0.233)	(0.143)	(9.705)
Panel B: T1 effect by quintile of $\hat{p}_i$ (Q1 = most left-leaning)								
T1 × Q1	0.082	0.013	0.123**	0.112*	0.002	-0.006	0.101*	-0.982
	(0.053)	(0.052)	(0.048)	(0.067)	(0.027)	(0.091)	(0.057)	(2.345)
T1 × Q2	0.030	0.060	-0.025	0.118**	-0.089	-0.030	0.074	1.722
	(0.052)	(0.048)	(0.063)	(0.054)	(0.086)	(0.062)	(0.080)	(2.971)
T1 × Q3	0.190***	0.097***	0.003	0.008	0.110	0.133**	0.265***	1.557
	(0.063)	(0.031)	(0.071)	(0.040)	(0.093)	(0.054)	(0.058)	(2.197)
T1 × Q4	0.195*	0.084	-0.041	-0.011	0.063	0.254***	0.261***	8.950***
	(0.116)	(0.087)	(0.093)	(0.080)	(0.125)	(0.081)	(0.086)	(3.299)
T1 × Q5	0.028	0.000	-0.178***	0.002	-0.055	0.108*	0.141**	1.247
	(0.069)	(0.056)	(0.044)	(0.089)	(0.076)	(0.060)	(0.062)	(2.016)
Other arms included	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524	4,524

Notes: $\hat{p}_i$ is the predicted probability of choosing the right article from a two-step post-LASSO logit: an ℓ_1-penalized logit on 77 baseline predictors, estimated on the choice arm, selects 16 predictors; an unpenalized logit on the selected predictors (cross-validated AUC 0.63) is then applied to all respondents (Table D.1). The UBI interaction is robust to the penalty rule used for selection: under the sklearn min-CV rule (41 predictors) it is -0.32 ($p = 0.015$), and under the one-SE rule (11 predictors) -0.52 ($p = 0.014$). Columns (1)–(7) in control-group SD units; column (8) in percentage points. Panel A interacts forced exposure with the centered propensity; a negative interaction on a pro-redistribution outcome indicates that right-leaning respondents move against the left article (backfire). Panel B replaces the linear interaction with quintile indicators. All models include T2 Read, T2 Skipped, T3 Left and T3 Right. Standard errors clustered at the federal-state level ($G = 16$) in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$. All specifications include stratification and demographic controls (nationality, age, gender, education, household income, marital status, religion, place of birth, employment, housing tenure, income source, and 2021 vote). Omitted category: no-article control group.

Table C.5. Information uptake: intent-to-treat versus effect per absorber

Uptake	First stage	F	Index	Wealth	Corp.	Inherit.	UBI	Min. wage
Panel A: Intent-to-treat reference (T1 vs. control)								
Forced exposure (ITT)	–	–	0.106**	0.057	0.162***	0.088**	-0.019	0.048*
			(0.041)	(0.035)	(0.043)	(0.039)	(0.026)	(0.025)
Panel B: Effect per absorber — 2SLS, uptake instrumented by T1 assignment								
Low-income, ±1	0.321	279	0.330***	0.177	0.506***	0.273**	-0.060	0.151**
(11% → 43%)	(0.019)		(0.125)	(0.109)	(0.126)	(0.121)	(0.077)	(0.071)
Low-income, ±2	0.308	342	0.343***	0.185	0.526***	0.284**	-0.062	0.157**
(21% → 52%)	(0.017)		(0.130)	(0.113)	(0.134)	(0.123)	(0.080)	(0.076)
Both, ±1	0.341	486	0.310***	0.167*	0.475***	0.256**	-0.056	0.141**
(7% → 41%)	(0.015)		(0.113)	(0.100)	(0.119)	(0.106)	(0.072)	(0.070)
Both, ±2	0.345	598	0.307***	0.165*	0.470***	0.254**	-0.056	0.140**
(14% → 49%)	(0.014)		(0.114)	(0.098)	(0.117)	(0.107)	(0.071)	(0.069)
Panel C: Over-identified 2SLS, uptake instrumented by T1, T2 and T3 assignment								
Low-income, ±1	–	169	0.403***	0.289***	0.546***	0.312***	-0.052	0.180**
overid. p			[0.39]	[0.01]	[0.61]	[0.17]	[0.06]	[0.52]
Low-income, ±2	–	210	0.420***	0.304***	0.567***	0.329***	-0.059	0.185**
overid. p			[0.40]	[0.02]	[0.57]	[0.19]	[0.06]	[0.51]
Both, ±1	–	260	0.380***	0.273***	0.516***	0.294***	-0.048	0.170**
overid. p			[0.39]	[0.01]	[0.62]	[0.16]	[0.06]	[0.53]
Both, ±2	–	317	0.376***	0.276***	0.507***	0.300***	-0.060	0.163**
overid. p			[0.37]	[0.02]	[0.49]	[0.20]	[0.06]	[0.48]
Panel D: Effect per absorber by right-leaning propensity (T1 instrument; low-income, ±1)								
Left-leaning half	0.299	123	0.481***	0.312**	0.559***	0.176	0.139	0.379***
(9% → 40%)	(0.027)		(0.114)	(0.133)	(0.166)	(0.164)	(0.160)	(0.124)
Right-leaning half	0.340	153	0.274	0.127	0.507***	0.439***	-0.262*	-0.006
(13% → 48%)	(0.027)		(0.206)	(0.180)	(0.141)	(0.158)	(0.154)	(0.139)

Notes: Uptake definitions: *Low-income* = answer to the low-income question within the margin of 10.7%; *Both* = answers to both questions within the margin of 10.7% and 7.9%; parentheses under each definition give the uptake rate in the control group and in T1. Information uptake is an indicator that the respondent's answer to the closing knowledge question(s) lies within the stated margin of the figure asserted by the left article (10.7% for low-income singles; 7.9% overall). Panel A reports the intent-to-treat effect of forced exposure for reference. Panel B reports two-stage least squares estimates of the effect of uptake on each outcome, instrumenting uptake with assignment to T1 on the sample of T1 and control respondents; the first stage is the effect of assignment on uptake and F its clustered F-statistic. Because assignment is random and never reduces uptake, the estimate is the effect of the article on respondents who absorb its facts (compliers), under the assumption that the article does not affect respondents who do not absorb them; since the article also contains an anecdote and explicit policy recommendations, this assumption is strong, and the estimates are best read as the intent-to-treat effect scaled to a per-absorber basis. Panel C adds assignment to T2 and T3 as instruments on the full sample; the bracketed p-value is Wooldridge's robust score test of overidentification, which rejects when the three arms imply different per-absorber effects. Panel D splits the T1–control sample at the median of the right-leaning propensity of Table D.1. Outcomes in control-group SD units. Standard errors clustered at the federal-state level ($G = 16$) in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$. All specifications include stratification and demographic controls (nationality, age, gender, education, household income, marital status, religion, place of birth, employment, housing tenure, income source, and 2021 vote). Omitted category: no-article control group.

D The Right-Leaning Propensity Score

Prediction P3 requires a measure of how congenial the left article is to a given respondent. We construct one from behaviour in the choice arm, where the preferred article is observed, and extrapolate it to respondents who were never given a choice.

Construction. The procedure has two steps. First, an ℓ_1-penalized logit of choosing the right article on all candidate predictors is estimated on the choice arm, with the penalty selected by 5-fold cross-validation; it retains 16 of 77 candidate columns. Second, an unpenalized logit on the retained predictors is estimated on the same arm and applied to every respondent, giving $\hat{p}_i$. The second step matters: predictions from the penalized fit are shrunk toward the mean, which compresses $\hat{p}_i$ and attenuates the interactions that test Prediction P3. The candidate set comprises the stratification and socio-demographic variables, the 2021 vote, political self-placement, the 46 named media outlets and the three main-source and secondary-source indicators, the three cognitive-dissonance items, and the justice question.

What is retained. Table D.1 reports the post-selection logit. Choice is predicted by partisanship, media diet and a few demographics. Readers of *Welt* and *Bild* (the conservative broadsheet and the right-leaning tabloid) and of Yahoo News are more likely to choose the growth article, as are full-time employees and, more weakly, CDU/CSU voters; SPD voters, respondents placing themselves on the left, those aged 25–34, and users of Instagram, Snapchat and TikTok are less likely. Neither education nor household income is retained. Neither is any of the three cognitive-dissonance items, nor the justice question: once partisanship and media habits are accounted for, general psychological dispositions add nothing to the prediction of which article a respondent opens. Coefficients are post-selection and should be read descriptively rather than as parameters with valid standard errors.

Fit. The model has a McFadden pseudo-R^2 of 0.053, an in-sample AUC of 0.658, and a 5-fold cross-validated AUC of 0.632 against a benchmark of 0.5 (Table D.1). It predicts choice, but coarsely: 62% of choices are classified correctly against 57% from always predicting the modal choice. Two consequences follow. Most of the variation in what people choose to read is not accounted for by observables, which is a substantive finding as much as a limitation. And because $\hat{p}_i$ is a noisy proxy, the interactions in Section 6.6 are attenuated, so the backfire estimates are conservative. Because the score is fitted on the choice arm alone, it is an out-of-sample prediction for the forced-exposure and control respondents whose comparison identifies those interactions.

Distribution and balance. $\hat{p}_i$ ranges from 0.09 to 0.91 with a standard deviation of 0.135. Within the choice arm it separates the two groups as intended: mean 0.53 among those who

chose the left article and 0.60 among those who chose the right one. Across the randomized arms it is balanced, with differences from the control group of −0.009 (T1, $p = 0.11$), −0.006 (T2, $p = 0.30$) and −0.002 (T3, $p = 0.70$), as it should be if assignment is random and treatment does not move the predictors.

Post-treatment predictors. Five candidate variables (the three dissonance items, the justice question and political self-placement) are elicited after the treatment block, because eliciting political attitudes beforehand would have primed the very responses the experiment measures. Three considerations bound the concern. The justice question is balanced across the randomized arms (Table C.1), and so is $\hat{p}_i$, which a treatment-induced shift in the retained predictors would unbalance. Only one of the five, self-placement, is retained by the LASSO. And re-estimating $\hat{p}_i$ with all five excluded strengthens the result: the interaction of forced exposure with $\hat{p}_i$ on UBI is −0.54 ($p = 0.04$), against −0.34 ($p = 0.06$) in the specification used in the text. The concern is not eliminated, since a measure taken before treatment would remove it by construction; it is one of the motivations for the second wave discussed in Section 8.4.

Table D.1. Right-leaning propensity: retained predictors and post-selection logit

Predictor	Coefficient	(SE)
Yahoo News	+0.749**	(0.363)
Self-placement: left (2 of 5)	-0.534***	(0.155)
Other traditional media	-0.512*	(0.284)
Age 25–34	-0.501***	(0.180)
2021 vote: SPD	-0.443***	(0.164)
Other online sources	-0.441*	(0.235)
Reads Bild	+0.356*	(0.212)
Snapchat	-0.342	(0.254)
Employed full-time	+0.307**	(0.132)
Instagram	-0.243	(0.159)
Reads Welt	+0.204	(0.156)
2021 vote: CDU/CSU	+0.181	(0.172)
Married	+0.176	(0.128)
Main source: social media	-0.168	(0.173)
TikTok	-0.131	(0.185)
Female	-0.129	(0.132)
Candidate predictors (after dummy expansion)	77	
Predictors retained by LASSO	16	
McFadden pseudo-R^2	0.053	
AUC, in-sample	0.658	
AUC, 5-fold cross-validated	0.632	
Observations (choice arm)	1,133	

Notes: Two-step post-LASSO procedure. Step 1: an ℓ_1-penalized logit of choosing the right article on all candidate predictors, estimated on the choice arm (T3) with the penalty chosen by 5-fold cross-validation (Stata `lasso logit, selection(cv)`), selects the predictors listed. Step 2: an unpenalized logit on the selected predictors, estimated on T3, yields $\hat{p}_i$ for every respondent. Coefficients are log-odds of choosing the right article with heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors; inference is post-selection and should be read descriptively. AUC = area under the ROC curve (0.5 = no predictive power); the cross-validated AUC holds the selected set fixed and is therefore mildly optimistic. Candidate predictors: stratification and socio-demographic variables, the 2021 vote, political self-placement, media consumption (main and secondary source and outlet-level indicators), the three cognitive-dissonance items, and the justice question. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

E Theory Appendix

E.1 Derivation of the Updating Weight

The posterior minimizes $L(\theta) = \alpha_i(\theta - \hat{\theta}_s)^2 + \kappa_i(\theta - \mu_i)^2$. The first-order condition $2\alpha_i(\theta - \hat{\theta}_s) + 2\kappa_i(\theta - \mu_i) = 0$ gives $(\alpha_i + \kappa_i)\theta = \alpha_i\hat{\theta}_s + \kappa_i\mu_i$, hence

$$\mu_i^{\text{post}} = \lambda_i\hat{\theta}_s + (1 - \lambda_i)\mu_i = \mu_i + \lambda_i(\hat{\theta}_s - \mu_i), \qquad \lambda_i = \frac{\alpha_i}{\alpha_i + \kappa_i}, \tag{E.1}$$

with $L'' = 2(\alpha_i + \kappa_i) > 0$ and $\partial\lambda_i/\partial\kappa_i = -\alpha_i/(\alpha_i + \kappa_i)^2 < 0$. Because λ_i depends only on the ratio $\alpha_i : \kappa_i$, the normalization $\alpha_i + \kappa_i = 1$ is without loss of generality at the updating stage, and then $\lambda_i = \alpha_i$.

E.2 Why Choice Requires a Cost of Exposure

Suppose the respondent anticipates choosing her posterior by (2) and takes the message as accurate, as the first term of the loss presumes. Let $d_s = \hat{\theta}_s - \mu_{is}$ be the distance between the message and her prior on the question the article argues (Section 2.3); for the left article $\mu_{iL} = \mu_i$. Reading moves her belief on that question by $\lambda_i d_s$: the distance between her belief and the message falls from $|d_s|$ to $(1 - \lambda_i)|d_s|$, and she bears the revision cost $\kappa_i\lambda_i^2 d_s^2$. The value of information from reading s rather than skipping is

$$V_i(s) \;=\; \alpha_i\big[1 - (1 - \lambda_i)^2\big]d_s^2 \;-\; \kappa_i\lambda_i^2 d_s^2 \;=\; \alpha_i\lambda_i\, d_s^2, \tag{E.2}$$

positive and increasing in the distance between message and prior, whatever κ_i. The conclusion does not require the message to be taken as fully accurate. If the respondent, judging from the headline, expects it to be accurate with probability q and uninformative otherwise, the truth then being drawn from her prior, and q is the same for both articles, the loss has the same form with $\alpha_i q$ in place of α_i and $\kappa_i + \alpha_i(1 - q)$ in place of κ_i, and $V_i(s) = \alpha_i q^2\lambda_i\, d_s^2$, again positive and increasing in distance. A respondent whose only psychological cost is the revision of her belief therefore never avoids a free article, and of two articles always prefers the one that disagrees with her more: she can limit the cost by updating less, and her optimal update weighs it against what she learns. Confirmatory choice requires a cost that updating less cannot undo, the exposure cost φ_i of (1). Reading confirmatory choice as evidence of φ_i also requires the two articles to be expected to be equally accurate: a respondent who expects the uncongenial article to be less accurate can choose the congenial one with $\varphi_i = 0$, as in the reputation model of Gentzkow and Shapiro (2006). This is the assumption stated in Section 2.3. The doubt about accuracy also matters for updating. With $q < 1$ the weight on the message becomes $\alpha_i q/(\alpha_i + \kappa_i) = q\lambda_i$: a reader whose doubt survives reading closes a share $q\lambda_i$ of the distance, so updating data identify $q\lambda_i$, and λ_i itself only under the normalization $q = 1$ of Section 2.3.

A q that is lower for respondents to whom the article is uncongenial would therefore lower their updating weight as well.

E.3 Two Tiers: Fact and Policy

The policy position minimizes (4). The first-order condition $\alpha_i\big(y-g_i(\mu_i^{\text{post}})\big)+\kappa_i^{\text{policy}}\big(y-y_i^0\big)=0$ gives (5), and the second derivative $2(\alpha_i+\kappa_i^{\text{policy}})$ is positive. The accuracy weight α_i is the same at both tiers; only the cost of revision is allowed to differ. With $y_i^0 = g_i(\mu_i)$ and g_i differentiable, the mean-value theorem gives $g_i(\mu_i^{\text{post}}) - y_i^0 = g_i'(\tilde{\mu}_i)\,\lambda_i(\hat{\theta}_s - \mu_i)$ for some $\tilde{\mu}_i$ between μ_i and μ_i^{post}, so that

$$y_i - y_i^0 \;=\; \lambda_i^{\text{policy}}\, g_i'(\tilde{\mu}_i)\,\lambda_i\,(\hat{\theta}_s - \mu_i). \tag{E.3}$$

The policy moves in the direction in which the fact points for the respondent, scaled by the weight on the fact and by the weight on the policy. If her position before reading differs from the one her prior implies, (5) adds the term $\lambda_i^{\text{policy}}\big(g_i(\mu_i) - y_i^0\big)$, which does not depend on the message; the assumption $y_i^0 = g_i(\mu_i)$ sets it to zero. Updating data on the fact identify λ_i, while the policy outcomes identify the product $\lambda_i^{\text{policy}} g_i'$ but not its factors. This is why the size of the effect of forced exposure on preferences does not discriminate between readings of the model (Appendix E.6).

E.4 Three Sources of Backfire

Both weights in (E.3) lie in $(0, 1)$, so the policy moves against the article only through one of three further ingredients.

Discounting the source. If the respondent treats the article as coming from a biased persuader, the perceived signal is $\tilde{\theta}_s = \hat{\theta}_s - \rho(\hat{\theta}_s - \mu_i)$ with $\rho \geq 0$, and the effective weight on the fact is $(1-\rho)\lambda_i$. For $\rho < 1$ the message is attenuated; for $\rho > 1$ it becomes evidence of the opposite. Both have micro-foundations. In the confirmatory bias of Rabin and Schrag (1999), a signal that contradicts the current belief is misread as supporting it with some probability, and when that probability is high enough the belief is expected to move away from the signal. In Fryer et al. (2019), evidence open to interpretation is encoded as consistent with the prior, so that people with different priors move apart on the same evidence. A reader may also treat the article as evidence about the sender's intent rather than about the world. None of these follows from (2), whose optimal weight on any message is positive, so we treat ρ as a reduced form. The first two require a message that can be misread or read more than one way, which a precise statistic does not easily allow. Because it acts on the factual belief, it predicts a lower, or negative, $\hat{\lambda}$ among respondents for whom the article is uncongenial, which Table 9 does not show.

Identity. Suppose the respondent also values distance between her position and the position

y_s that the article argues for, with weight η_i, so that she minimizes

$$\alpha_i\big(y - g_i(\mu_i^{\text{post}})\big)^2 + \kappa_i^{\text{policy}}\big(y - y_i^0\big)^2 - \eta_i\big(y - y_s\big)^2. \tag{E.4}$$

The loss is convex if $\alpha_i + \kappa_i^{\text{policy}} > \eta_i$, and the first-order condition gives

$$y_i - y_i^0 \;=\; \frac{\alpha_i\big(g_i(\mu_i^{\text{post}}) - y_i^0\big) - \eta_i\big(y_s - y_i^0\big)}{\alpha_i + \kappa_i^{\text{policy}} - \eta_i}. \tag{E.5}$$

When the article argues for the position the fact implies, $y_s = g_i(\mu_i^{\text{post}})$, the weight on that position is $(\alpha_i - \eta_i)/(\alpha_i + \kappa_i^{\text{policy}} - \eta_i)$. It lies below $\lambda_i^{\text{policy}}$ for $0 < \eta_i < \alpha_i$, turns negative for $\eta_i > \alpha_i$, and exceeds $\lambda_i^{\text{policy}}$ for $\eta_i < 0$, a respondent who wants to stand with the source. Writing the weight as $(1 - \rho_i^{\text{policy}})\lambda_i^{\text{policy}}$ gives

$$\rho_i^{\text{policy}} \;=\; \frac{\eta_i\,\kappa_i^{\text{policy}}}{\alpha_i\big(\alpha_i + \kappa_i^{\text{policy}} - \eta_i\big)}, \tag{E.6}$$

which exceeds one exactly when $\eta_i > \alpha_i$: at the policy tier, discounting beyond one is what an identity motive stronger than the accuracy motive produces. The cost of revision does not cause the reversal, but through the convexity condition it bounds how far the respondent moves away. Because the factual belief is untouched, identity leaves $\hat{\lambda}$ unaffected and predicts backfire on the policies whose positions mark group membership. The condition $\eta_i > \alpha_i$ applies when the article argues for exactly the position the fact implies. If it argues for more, $y_s - y_i^0 > g_i(\mu_i^{\text{post}}) - y_i^0 > 0$, (E.5) is negative whenever $\eta_i(y_s - y_i^0) > \alpha_i\big(g_i(\mu_i^{\text{post}}) - y_i^0\big)$, so a weak identity motive suffices on a policy for which, in the respondent's view, the fact makes only a weak case. As with φ_i, the data identify a sign only: backfire on a policy says that the identity motive outweighs the accuracy motive for the respondents who show it.

A different mapping. If $g_i' < 0$, (E.3) is negative with both weights in $(0, 1)$ and no identity motive: the respondent accepts the fact and moves away from the article's conclusion because, in her model of the economy, the fact argues against it. A respondent who believes that transfers feed inflation reads a higher inflation burden on the poor as a reason for fewer transfers. This also leaves $\hat{\lambda}$ unaffected and predicts backfire on the policies for which her model reverses the sign of the article's argument.

The second and third ingredients make the same predictions in this wave. They differ in what the reversal responds to. Identity is attached to the position of the source, so the same article attributed to an outlet on the respondent's own side should move her toward it; a different mapping does not depend on the source, and a question on what the policy would do reveals its sign (Section 8.4).

E.5 Two Policy Dimensions: The Platform Ranking

Section 8.2 argues that the bundling of fiscal with migration positions in the platforms shapes how persuasion on economics turns into votes. A spatial model makes the argument precise. Each platform $j \in \{\pi, \theta, \omega, \sigma\}$ (Table B.1) combines a fiscal position f_j, higher for more redistribution, with a migration position m_j, higher for more restriction, and the design aligns the two: $f_\pi > f_\theta > f_\omega > f_\sigma$ and $m_\pi < m_\theta < m_\omega < m_\sigma$. Respondent i, with ideal point (f_i, m_i), ranks the platforms by

$$U_{ij} \;=\; -\,w_f\,(f_j - f_i)^2 \;-\; w_m\,(m_j - m_i)^2 \;+\; \varepsilon_{ij}, \tag{E.7}$$

where ε_{ij} is a taste shock. A narrative shifts her fiscal ideal point by δ, positive for the left article, and leaves m_i and the weights unchanged. For any two platforms,

$$\Delta U_{ij} - \Delta U_{ik} \;=\; 2\,w_f\,\delta\,(f_j - f_k), \tag{E.8}$$

which yields three results. First, the shift reorders the platforms by their fiscal positions alone, whatever the respondent's migration preference. Second, it changes her first choice only if the utility gap between that platform and one further in the direction of the shift is smaller than the gain in (E.8). With aligned platforms, the gap between a right and a left platform contains the migration term $w_m\left[(m_\theta - m_i)^2 - (m_\omega - m_i)^2\right]$, which is large for a respondent with restrictive views, so a leftward shift reorders her ranking within the right pair and rarely carries her across. This is the bundling argument of Roemer (1998): persuasion on one dimension moves votes only where the other dimension allows. Third, the platform at the end of the fiscal scale opposite to the shift cannot gain at the expense of another platform. Under a leftward shift every platform gains on σ, so no respondent who ranked another platform first switches to it; it can gain only from respondents who left the ranking blank and whose fiscal ideal lies to the right of its own. Under a rightward shift the same holds for π.

The model thus predicts that the left article cannot raise the far-right share, moves first choices out of the Center-Right only toward the left platforms and only for respondents near indifference, and draws some far-right voters to the Center-Right; and that the right article raises the appeal of the far-right platform relative to every other and cannot raise the share of the Left platform. Three features of Table 5 bear on these predictions. Among respondents who chose the left article, the Center-Right's loss is matched by the gains of the two left platforms, as the model requires, although each gain is imprecise and the comparison is between self-selected groups (Appendix E.6). Respondents who chose the right article rank the far-right platform first more often and the Center-Left less often, as a rightward shift implies, but this comparison also contains a selection term, and the right article links the citizen's allowance to foreign recipients (Appendix A.2), so it may move m_i as well as f_i. Under forced exposure to the left article, a randomized comparison, and among its voluntary readers, the far-right share rises, by about as

much as among those who chose the right article. The third result rules this out unless the gain comes entirely from respondents who had left the ranking blank and whose fiscal ideal lies to the right of a flat tax with large corporate tax cuts. More plausibly, the article moves something the model holds fixed, such as the weight on migration or the appeal of a platform as a vehicle of protest.

E.6 The Three Readings of the Model

Table 8 restricts the model of Section 2 in three ways. Under (A), accuracy only, $\varphi_i = \kappa_i = \kappa_i^{\text{policy}} = \eta_i = 0$. Under (B), dissonance only, the costs of exposure and of revision are large, at both tiers, for respondents to whom the message is uncongenial. Under (C), the hybrid, the cost of exposure governs the choice ($\varphi_i > \alpha_i\lambda_i$), the cost of revising the fact is close to zero ($\kappa_i \approx 0$), and resistance is confined to the policy tier: $\kappa_i^{\text{policy}} > 0$, and on the contested policy either $\eta_i > \alpha_i$ or $g_i' < 0$. The verdicts in Panel A follow from the model.

Row 1. Under (A), (E.2) with $\lambda_i = 1$ gives $V_i(s) = \alpha_i d_s^2$: a respondent who expects both articles to be equally accurate reads the one farther from her prior, so choice is counter-attitudinal. Under (B) and (C), $\varphi_i > \alpha_i\lambda_i$ makes it confirmatory. (A) produces confirmatory choice only if the uncongenial article is expected to be less accurate. If that expectation survived reading, it would lower the updating weight of the same respondents (Appendix E.2), which Table 9 does not show, to the extent that the answers measure belief rather than recall.

Row 2. Under (A) and (C), $\lambda_i \approx 1$ for every respondent, so $\hat{\lambda}$ does not vary with $\hat{p}_i$; the shortfall of the estimates from one reflects rounding (Section 8.3) or a common $q < 1$ (Appendix E.2). Under (B), κ_i is larger for respondents to whom the left article is uncongenial, so λ_i falls with $\hat{p}_i$. The verdict against (B) holds to the extent that the answers measure belief rather than recall: a respondent who discounts the article can still report its figure.

Row 3. By (E.3), forced exposure moves a policy by $\mathbb{E}\big[\lambda_i^{\text{policy}} g_i'(\tilde{\mu}_i)\lambda_i(\hat{\theta}_s - \mu_i)\big]$. Its sign follows the mapping and its size depends on g_i', which no reading fixes, so every reading produces a weak and uneven effect for some mappings.

Row 4. Under (A), the policy moves fully to $g_i(\mu_i^{\text{post}})$; under (B), a cost of revision slows its movement without reversing it (Appendix E.4). Either reading produces backfire only if $g_i' < 0$ for the respondents who show it. Under (C), the reversal on the contested policy comes from $\eta_i > \alpha_i$ or from $g_i' < 0$, and nothing reverses the factual belief.

Panel B. For a group defined by its own choice c, such as the respondents in T3 who chose the left article, the decomposed specification (8) estimates, conditional on the controls,

$$\beta_c = \underbrace{\mathbb{E}\big[y_i^0 \mid c\big] - \mathbb{E}\big[y_i^0\big]}_{\text{selection}} + \underbrace{\mathbb{E}\big[y_i - y_i^0 \mid c\big]}_{\text{movement}}. \tag{E.9}$$

Under (B) and (C), $\varphi_i > \alpha_i\lambda_i$ sorts respondents whose priors are close to the left article into reading it, so the selection term is positive for left-choosers and negative for right-choosers;

under (A) the signs reverse. Given the sorting observed in row 1, the ordering of row 5 therefore follows under any updating rule: left-choosers can end 0.27 SD above the control group with no more movement than forced readers, simply by starting higher. Skippers receive no message, so for them β_c is the selection term alone (row 6), and its sign discriminates. Under (A) with a small cost of reading, a respondent skips the left article when $\alpha_i q_i^2 d_{iL}^2$ falls short of that cost. If α_i and q_i are common, the skippers are those whose priors lie closest to the article, and their selection term is positive, the opposite of row 6. (A) fits row 6 only if right-leaning respondents care less about accuracy on this topic or trust the article less, the second being the assumption under which it passes row 1. Under (B) and (C), $\varphi_i > \alpha_i \lambda_i$ makes the skippers those to whom the article is uncongenial, and the negative sign follows. The gap between the two T3 coefficients (row 7) is the difference between two such sums. The controls, which include the 2021 vote, remove selection on observables but not on preferences that differ within them.

E.7 Identification Note

Equation (3) has the algebraic form of a normal-normal posterior mean with α_i in the role of signal precision and κ_i in the role of prior precision. Updating data alone therefore cannot distinguish a respondent who dislikes revising her belief from a confident Bayesian: both move little. By Appendix E.2, the selection stage does not separate them either, since neither ever finds a free article aversive; what the selection stage is informative about is the exposure cost φ_i. The confirmatory sorting in the choice arm is evidence that $\varphi_i > \alpha_i \lambda_i$ on average: both articles carried the same displayed reading time, so the cost of reading cannot explain which one is chosen. The 13% who decline a free article in the optional arm are consistent with $\varphi_i > 0$ as well, though a cost of reading would produce them too. Neither measures φ_i, which requires a willingness-to-pay elicitation (Section 8.4) to price exposure in money; separating κ_i from prior precision requires a measure of prior confidence, which observes precision directly.